OMUGWO

The Season Mother Came

A novella

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Story by Henry Loveday

OMUGWO: THE SEASON MOTHER CAME

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This is a work of fiction. Characters, dialogue, and events are presented as part of a fictional narrative.

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Chapter One: The Arrival

A woman can spend nine months carrying a child, endure the pain of childbirth, and still find herself being asked, before she has properly rested, whether she has started losing the baby weight.

People come to admire the baby. They bring gifts, take photographs, argue over whose nose the child inherited, and ask when they can visit again.

But who is looking after the mother?

Among the Igbo people of southeastern Nigeria, there is a tradition called **Omugwo**. After childbirth, a woman's mother, mother-in-law, or another trusted relative may come to stay and help her settle into motherhood. She cooks, helps care for the baby, takes on household responsibilities, and passes down the knowledge she has gathered over the years.

Omugwo is more than cooking and carrying a newborn. It is also the familiar sound of a mother giving instructions nobody requested, the comfort of having someone nearby during a difficult night, and the occasional disagreement between two women who love each other but have different ideas about how things should be done.

Every family experiences it differently. Some mothers remember those weeks with gratitude. Others have stories that still make the family argue years later.

This is the story of one such family.

And it begins in a Houston apartment, three days after a baby boy was born.

Nwagaga arrived with a bag of dried fish, a bundle of leaves Akudo couldn't name, and no plan to leave.

At eleven seventeen that Thursday morning, somebody knocked on the apartment door. Three quick knocks, a pause, then two more. Rosiline Akudo, known simply as Akudo to her family, recognised the rhythm, although the person who usually made it was supposed to be several thousand miles away.

Her three-day-old son was asleep against her chest. The air conditioner hummed above the living-room window, fighting

Houston's October warmth, while a work email waited on her phone. She had promised David that she would stop checking messages until Monday. She had also told herself that reading an email was different from answering one.

Kamsi stirred before she could finish the first paragraph. Akudo lowered the phone and watched his chest rise beneath the thin cotton of his shirt. She had become an expert at watching him breathe, though almost everything else about having a baby remained astonishingly unfamiliar. Yesterday she had spent ten minutes worrying about a sound that turned out to be a hiccup.

The knocking came again.

"Ahn-ahn. It cannot be."

"David!"

"Yeah?"

"Somebody is at the door."

"I heard."

"Then why are you still in the kitchen?"

David appeared with a mug of coffee. He had slept in a T-shirt he would normally consider too old for company, but three nights with a newborn had changed his standards.

"Are we expecting anyone?"

"Would I be asking you to open the door if I knew who it was?"

He put down his mug.

The moment he turned the lock, a familiar voice came through the doorway.

"David, my son! Kedu? Please, let me enter before this bag removes my shoulder."

Akudo sat upright.

"Mom?"

Nwagaga stepped inside wearing a purple wrapper, a neatly pressed blouse, and a headscarf that had survived an international flight without surrendering its shape. Her handbag hung from one shoulder, a travelling bag pulled at the other, and a suitcase stood behind her in the corridor. She smelled faintly of perfume and the dried ingredients she had packed for the journey.

David moved aside, startled into courtesy.

“Mom! Welcome. Give me that bag.”

“Daalụ, my son.”

He took the travelling bag and nearly lost his balance.

“What did you put in here?”

“Food.”

“All of this?”

“My son, I brought enough food from Nigeria to make sure you and Akudo are comfortable.”

Akudo made a sound that began as a protest and ended in laughter. David carried the bag into the sitting room with both arms wrapped around it. He had learned that his mother-in-law expressed affection through food, instructions, and questions for which she expected immediate answers. Evidently, she had brought a generous supply of all three.

“Mom!”

Nwagaga turned toward the sofa.

“Akudo!”

She crossed the room before her daughter could attempt to stand. Her hands were on Akudo’s face almost at once, examining her cheeks and eyes with the concentration of somebody checking fruit at the market.

“Chineke. Look at you.”

“Mom, why didn’t you call from the airport? David would have picked you up.”

“Your younger brother collected me.”

“My brother? From New York?”

“He came yesterday evening. You know that boy. He enjoys arranging things behind people’s backs.”

Akudo glanced toward the door. “Where is he?”

“Outside. He said I should tell you to rest instead of organising airport transport three days after giving birth.”

Before Akudo could answer, her brother appeared in the doorway, holding his car keys.

“So you people decided to keep a secret from me?” Akudo demanded.

He smiled.

He stepped close enough to admire the baby, accepted Akudo's warning that she would deal with him properly on their next phone call, and left soon afterwards to begin the journey back. There was no argument over whether he should stay. Nwagaga had already dismissed him with a container of food and repeated instructions to call when he reached home.

Akudo watched him go, still trying to understand how her family had managed the surprise without somebody accidentally mentioning it on the telephone.

"You should have told me," she said when David shut the door.

"And allowed you to start worrying about my flight? No, thank you." Nwagaga drew a chair toward the sofa. "Now let me see you properly."

"I'm fine."

"Who said you are not fine?"

"You're checking my face as though something happened to it."

"Something did happen. You gave birth."

Akudo had no answer to that.

Nwagaga noticed the baby before she could invent one.

"Let me see my grandchild?"

Akudo loosened the blanket enough for her mother to see him. The apartment had been full of Nwagaga's voice since the door opened; now, as she leaned over the sleeping child, her words deserted her. One hand hovered near his tiny fist before she drew it back, unwilling to wake him.

She had helped other women after childbirth. Akudo knew the stories: a cousin whose mother was ill, a neighbour with nobody nearby, a family friend whose relatives lived too far away to travel. But this was Nwagaga's own first grandson, and Akudo was her first child to become a mother.

"Kamsiyochukwu," she whispered. "Our Henry."

The baby slept through the introduction.

"Hey. See this boy. Three days old and already looking as if somebody is owing him money."

"Mom."

"Look at that forehead. Serious man."

David came over to inspect the evidence. “He gets that from Akudo.”

“Excuse me?”

“Yes,” Nwagaga said. “My daughter knows how to squeeze face when she is not happy.”

“Both of you should leave my son out of this.”

“Am I lying?”

David wisely found somewhere else to direct his attention. He picked up the folded baby blanket from the arm of the sofa and began straightening it, although it was already perfectly straight.

Akudo had not seen her mother in almost two years. They had spoken on video calls, sometimes for an hour, with the same familiar arguments about whether she was eating enough and why she did not call more often. Yet the screen had never carried Nwagaga’s perfume, the rustle of her wrapper, or the warmth of the hands that had just held her face.

Nwagaga lowered herself beside her daughter.

“Nwa m, how are you feeling?”

“Tired.”

“Are you sleeping?”

“When he allows it.”

“How often is that?”

Akudo considered the question. “You know those very short naps you take when the electricity goes off, and the room becomes hot?”

Nwagaga made a sympathetic noise.

“It is like that. Except I’m the one supplying the electricity.”

“Poor thing. Give me your hand.”

Akudo let her mother take it. There was an old comfort in the familiar grip, though she had not decided whether to admit how badly she needed it. She had imagined her first week at home would be difficult. She had not expected to feel so uncertain in a house where she knew where every plate belonged.

“Have you eaten this morning?” Nwagaga asked.

“Toast.”

“Only toast?”

“And tea.”

“Tea!”

David, who had been heading toward the kitchen, stopped.

“My son, what has my daughter been eating?”

“David,” Akudo warned, “don’t answer that.”

“I wasn’t planning to.”

“Good decision.”

Nwagaga adjusted her wrapper. “Look at this one. She has given birth, and she is eating toast.”

“Mom, people eat toast every day.”

“Are you people?”

David turned toward the kitchen before either woman could see his face.

“What does that even mean?” Akudo asked.

“It means I need to see what is in your kitchen.”

“Mom, you only just arrived.”

“And is the kitchen going to disappear because I have not rested?”

Akudo could already imagine cupboards being opened, questions about the refrigerator, and some dispute involving the size of the pots. Her mother had been there less than half an hour. The apartment, which had belonged entirely to Akudo and David the previous morning, was beginning to feel like a place Nwagaga had been appointed to supervise.

“And which room am I sleeping in?” Nwagaga asked.

David reappeared at the doorway. His gaze moved from the suitcase to Akudo, who was hoping he might offer an answer on her behalf.

“Mom,” Akudo began, “how long are you staying?”

“How long do you need me?”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

“And I have answered you.”

Akudo examined her mother’s expression. There was no point continuing the argument while Kamsi slept on her chest and David stood nearby pretending to be fascinated by his coffee mug.

“David will show you the guest room.”

“Good. After that, I want to see the kitchen.”

“I knew you were going to say that.”

“Then you are still a clever girl.”

Within thirty minutes, Nwagaga had inspected the kitchen and opened enough cupboards to understand why Akudo was constantly reaching across the stove for a cooking spoon. She found the pots inconveniently placed, the plates too far from the sink, and a frying pan living where she believed the cooking utensils ought to be.

Akudo stood in the doorway, holding Kamsi while David unloaded the groceries her mother had brought. She wanted to tell Nwagaga that the kitchen arrangement worked perfectly well for two people who had lived there for years. At the same time, she was grateful somebody else had volunteered to deal with lunch.

Nwagaga picked up an onion.

“See this onion.”

David glanced over. “What’s wrong with it?”

“Too small.”

“It’s an onion.”

“And I said it is too small.”

He took it back and placed it on the chopping board.

“All right. What should I do with this one?”

“Cut it.”

“How?”

“Normally.”

David reached for the knife.

Nwagaga watched him make the first cut.

“Akudo, come and show me how you cut onions these days. I want to see what Houston has taught you.”

“I gave birth three days ago, Mom. Surely I’m excused from the onion examination.”

“Ah. Now she remembers she must rest.”

David set down the knife. “Is there a special family method?”

“With love,” Akudo said.

“Exactly,” Nwagaga replied, although she continued inspecting his work.

David cut the onion and moved the pieces into a bowl. He was beginning to understand that the main challenge of living with

Nwagaga would be discovering which instructions were serious and which were simply part of a conversation she intended to win.

"Mom," he said, "should I cut another one?"

"Let me see this one first."

He waited with the knife in his hand. Akudo caught his eye from the doorway, and neither needed to say a word.

The apartment smelled of onions, dried fish, and the first spices warming in a pot. Somewhere outside, a car alarm sounded twice and stopped. Kamsi shifted against Akudo's shoulder, and she moved into the sitting room to settle him before the kitchen became any noisier.

For three days, she and David had eaten meals whenever they remembered, slept in pieces, and spoken in whispers for fear of disturbing the baby. Now someone was moving through their kitchen with complete confidence, and David had been assigned to onion duty.

Nwagaga called from the stove.

"Akudo! Where do you keep your bigger pot?"

"Second cupboard on the left."

"Why is it there?"

"Because that is where we keep it!"

"Hmm. We shall discuss that one."

Akudo leaned back against the sofa. She had heard that particular *hmm* throughout her childhood, and she knew perfectly well what it meant. There would be changes in the kitchen before evening.

Across the room, the guest-room door stood half open. Nwagaga's suitcase rested beside the bed, her wrapper was folded over a chair, and her handbag sat within easy reach of the pillow.

When David offered to move it onto the dressing table, Nwagaga came out of the kitchen almost immediately.

"Leave that one, my son. I will keep it here."

He let go of the strap.

She carried the handbag back into the guest room herself, closed the door partway, and returned to the stove.

Akudo watched her go.

Chapter Two: The Brown Envelope

By early afternoon, Nwagaga had unpacked enough of her luggage to make the guest room look occupied. Her suitcase stood open beside the wardrobe, and a purple wrapper lay across the foot of the bed. On the dressing table, she had arranged a bottle of perfume, a small tin of face cream, and a framed photograph of Akudo's late father.

Akudo had come to help her put away the remaining clothes. Instead, she stopped at the photograph.

Her father was wearing the traditional outfit he favoured for family occasions. He had one hand resting on the arm of a chair and the slightly impatient expression he always wore when somebody made him pose for a picture. She remembered that outfit. She also remembered him telling her mother that a man ought to be allowed to sit down at a party without being photographed twenty times.

"I brought him," Nwagaga said.

Akudo picked up the frame, careful not to leave fingerprints on the glass. "You still travel with this?"

"When I am going to stay somewhere for a while."

"How long is a while?"

"You have already asked me that question today."

"I still haven't received an answer."

"Then perhaps you are asking it badly."

Akudo put the photograph back. They could argue about the length of the visit another day.

As she turned toward the wardrobe, she noticed the brown envelope.

It lay beside Nwagaga's handbag, partly covered by the end of a folded wrapper. The paper had yellowed around the edges. A name was written across the front in blue ink; the letters formed with a care she recognised before she recognised the handwriting.

Akudo.

Not Rosiline. Her Igbo name.

She lifted a corner of the wrapper.

"Mom, what is this?"

Nwagaga stopped folding a blouse.

“Leave that one.”

“It has my name on it.”

“I can see that.”

“Who wrote it?”

Her mother took the envelope from the table. She held it by the edges, as though she were afraid of damaging the paper, before slipping it into her handbag.

“Your grandmother left it with me.”

“Ǹmá?”

“Yes.”

Akudo had expected an explanation, and for an instant the answer pleased her. She knew her grandmother’s handwriting from birthday cards and the labels she used to tie onto gifts. Ǹmá had liked putting people’s names on things, even when everybody in the house knew who owned them.

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

“I have only just arrived.”

“Mom, she died years ago.”

Nwagaga closed the handbag. “And the letter has waited years. It can wait until we have eaten.”

“That is not your decision to make.”

“No,” her mother said, and Akudo heard the effort it cost her to agree. “But I am asking you to give me today.”

Akudo wanted to take the envelope and read it there. Nothing in the room prevented her except the expression on her mother’s face. Nwagaga was rarely uncertain about what she wanted. Even when she was wrong, she usually sounded confident enough to make everyone else question themselves.

Now she was gripping the handbag strap with both hands.

“Is it something bad?” Akudo asked.

“It is something I should have given you before now.”

The answer was too careful to be comforting.

From the kitchen came the metallic clatter of a pot. David called to ask whether the onions on the counter were meant for lunch or dinner.

“All of them!” Nwagaga called back.

“All of them?”

“David, my son, how many times must an onion receive permission before it enters a pot?”

Akudo might have enjoyed the exchange on another day. She returned to the wardrobe and began hanging the remaining clothes, leaving the space between herself and her mother undisturbed.

By evening, the apartment smelled of peppers, dried fish, and the spices Nwagaga had carried from Nigeria. She had made pepper soup with pieces of white yam, set pap aside for the morning, and insisted on cooking enough food that David could take some for lunch the following day.

He had washed vegetables and cleared the counter without being asked. When Nwagaga requested a particular pot, he found it in the cupboard she had reorganised that afternoon, though he still had to open two doors before remembering where she had moved it.

Akudo sat at the table while her mother served the soup. The air conditioner rattled once overhead. Outside, the light had begun to fade behind the apartment buildings.

The first spoonful tasted of home.

She remembered the kitchen in Nigeria: her younger sister claiming the biggest piece of meat before anybody had sat down, her brother insisting he had been cheated, and their father holding his newspaper high enough to suggest he was staying out of the argument. Ǹmá would be nearby, usually with a correction to somebody’s version of a family story.

“This is good, Mom.”

Nwagaga placed another piece of yam in her bowl.

“I know.”

“You could at least pretend to be humble.”

“For what? Did I spoil the soup?”

“No.”

“Then eat it while it is hot.”

David reached for his water glass. “I’m beginning to understand why Akudo never accepts a compliment.”

“That one is not from me,” Nwagaga said. “She learned it somewhere in America.”

“I’m sitting right here,” Akudo reminded them.

“We can see you, nwa m. Eat.”

Akudo did. She had gone most of the afternoon with little appetite, distracted first by her mother’s unexpected arrival and then by the envelope. Now the food was warm, Kamsi was asleep nearby, and David had stopped glancing at the work notifications lighting up her phone.

For a little while, nobody asked her to make a decision.

After dinner, David took the plates to the kitchen while Akudo and Nwagaga carried Kamsi into the bedroom to change his diaper.

Nwagaga spread a clean changing mat on the bed and laid out a fresh diaper. Akudo settled Kamsi onto the mat while her mother stood beside her, ready to help. They worked together, with Nwagaga passing what was needed and Akudo keeping a hand securely on her son.

“Your hand should stay there,” Nwagaga said. “These small people can surprise you.”

“He can barely move.”

“Today. Tomorrow you will say he has begun organising himself.”

Kamsi stretched one leg as though offering an opinion. Akudo caught his foot before it reached the clean diaper.

“See?” Nwagaga said.

“He is three days old, Mom. He is not planning an escape.”

“He has started by testing the security.”

The diaper was changed without further negotiations. Akudo fastened Kamsi’s little shirt, and Nwagaga gathered the used things for disposal.

For the first time since the guest-room conversation, Akudo had nearly forgotten the envelope.

Then her mother reached into the pocket of her wrapper, searching for a handkerchief, and Akudo remembered the way she had held the old paper.

She could still picture the blue handwriting.

Ǹmá had been dead for years. Whatever she had wanted her granddaughter to know had travelled all that time in Nwagaga's handbag, or perhaps in a drawer back in Nigeria. Akudo wondered how many journeys the envelope had made without her knowing it existed.

She settled Kamsi in his bassinet and checked that he was comfortable. Nwagaga disposed of the diaper and washed her hands.

"Mom," Akudo said when she returned, "I will give it to you today. But tomorrow we talk about the letter."

Nwagaga dried her hands on a towel. "Tomorrow."

"And you won't decide I'm too tired to hear it?"

"I won't use your tiredness as an excuse."

Akudo held her gaze long enough to be sure she had heard correctly.

"Thank you."

Nwagaga folded the towel and hung it over the rail. She did not appear relieved by the agreement. If anything, the prospect of tomorrow troubled her more than the questions had.

* * *

At half past two, Akudo woke to footsteps in the hallway.

David was sleeping beside her, one arm tucked beneath his pillow. Kamsi lay in the bassinet near the bed. The apartment was cool enough that Akudo pulled the sheet around her shoulders before listening again.

A door clicked shut.

She knew the sound of the guest-room door. Nwagaga had been using it throughout the evening, opening it to fetch things Akudo had forgotten a person might need after a long flight: a shawl, a pair of slippers, a different nightdress.

But there was no reason to be searching through luggage at half past two.

Akudo got out of bed and crossed the hallway. A thin strip of light showed beneath the guest-room door.

Inside, Nwagaga sat on the edge of the bed with her handbag in her lap. The framed photograph of Akudo's father stood on the dressing

table, turned slightly toward her. She was speaking in Igbo, so low that Akudo caught only fragments.

Her own name.

Her younger sister's name.

And a prayer.

"Chukwu biko," Nwagaga said. "Please, let me do the right thing this time."

Akudo stopped outside the door.

She had heard her mother pray over meals, before journeys, during illnesses, and whenever anyone in the family called with troubling news. Nwagaga prayed with the same determination she brought to cooking: directly, thoroughly, and without much patience for interruption.

Tonight her voice sounded worn.

Akudo tapped the door with her knuckles.

"Mom?"

Nwagaga shut the handbag.

"Akudo. Why are you awake?"

"I heard you moving around."

"I couldn't sleep."

"Neither could I after hearing you pray like that."

Nwagaga set the handbag beside her and moved a pile of folded clothes from the chair.

"Come and sit, then. Since both of us are awake."

Akudo sat. The room smelled of Nwagaga's familiar perfume, with a trace of the food she had been cooking earlier. An unopened suitcase rested beside the wardrobe, its zip straining around clothes and packages that still needed putting away.

"You mentioned my sister," Akudo said.

"I was praying for all of you."

"And me?"

"Especially you. You have just become a mother."

Akudo rubbed her eyes. "Mom, being a mother doesn't mean I've suddenly become someone who can't hear difficult things."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Nwagaga picked a loose thread from the edge of her wrapper. She had been doing small household tasks all evening, as though keeping her hands occupied made the rest of life easier to manage.

“Your grandmother was frightened by certain things in our family,” she said.

“The same things that are in the letter?”

“Some of them.”

Akudo waited, but her mother did not continue.

“Is that why you mentioned Kamsi earlier?”

Nwagaga's fingers stopped moving.

“I worry about all my children and grandchildren.”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

“No. It isn’t.”

Akudo leaned back in the chair. Her mother could have denied that the envelope had anything to do with Kamsi. Instead, she had left Akudo to imagine the connection for herself.

“I don’t like this,” Akudo said. “You come all the way from Nigeria, carry a letter with my name on it, and suddenly everybody seems to know something I don’t.”

“Not everybody.”

“You know what I mean.”

“Yes.”

Akudo could hear David turning over in the bedroom down the hall.

“When I was small,” Nwagaga said, “your grandmother kept a wooden box in her room. Do you remember it?”

Akudo had not thought about the box in years. It had stood inside a cupboard, beneath folded wrappers and a small collection of papers. Ǹmá kept the cupboard locked when visitors came, although the grandchildren had been convinced it contained money.

“I remember trying to guess what she put inside,” Akudo said. “My sister thought there was gold.”

“Your sister thought many things.”

“She still does.”

Nwagaga ran a finger along the seam of the handbag.

“Your grandmother kept old family things. Letters. Photographs. Papers she could not bear to throw away.”

“And this was one of them?”

“Yes.”

Akudo studied her mother. The box was an answer of sorts, though not to the question she most wanted to ask.

“Why was Ǹmá afraid?”

Nwagaga drew the handbag closer.

“Because there were losses in our family that she never stopped thinking about. And because some older relatives had their own beliefs about what those losses meant.”

“What beliefs?”

“About a promise made a long time ago.”

Akudo felt the words land without finding anywhere to put them. She knew the stories relatives told about the past, the ones that became more elaborate whenever somebody tried to correct a detail. But she had never heard her grandmother speak of a promise as though it belonged to the family itself.

“Do you believe it?” she asked.

“I believe people can be frightened for a long time after something terrible happens. I also know fear can make a person listen to the wrong advice.”

“Did Ǹmá listen to somebody like that?”

Nwagaga did not answer immediately. She reached across to straighten the photograph on the dressing table, though it was already standing properly.

“Tomorrow,” she said at last. “I promised you tomorrow, and I mean to keep my word.”

Akudo disliked the answer, but she had extracted the promise herself. She was too tired to turn it into another argument.

“Don’t change your mind in the morning.”

“I won’t.”

She stood to leave. At the door, she turned back.

“Mom, when you say there were losses…”

Nwagaga had already opened her handbag. She was holding the brown envelope between her fingers, looking down at the writing on the front.

Akudo waited for her to answer.

Instead, her mother placed the envelope on the bedside table, beneath the photograph of Akudo's father.

"Go and check on your son, nwa m."

Akudo returned to the bedroom without closing the guest-room door completely. David was asleep again. Kamsi had worked one small hand free of his blanket, and she stood beside the bassinet until she was satisfied he was comfortable.

In the hallway, Nwagaga switched off the guest-room light.

A few minutes later, Akudo heard her mother humming the familiar tune she had sung to her children when they were small. It drifted through the apartment for a little while, and then stopped.

Akudo was still awake when the clock turned three.

Chapter Three: Hot Water

By six-thirty on Friday morning, Nwagaga was already in the kitchen.

She tied her wrapper firmly at the waist and opened the cupboard beneath the counter, where she found the frying pan she had complained about the day before. She moved it beside the stove, rearranged two pots, and stood back to inspect the result. The kitchen made more sense to her now, although she still could not understand why Akudo kept the cooking spoons so far from the place where she cooked.

The kettle was beginning to warm when David appeared, barefoot and wearing the same tired expression he had carried to bed.

“Mom.”

“Good morning, my son. Did you sleep?”

“A little.”

“How many times did Kamsi wake?”

“Twice.”

“Only twice? Ah, you have not started.”

“I thought fatherhood started when he was born.”

“You have registered. The real examination is coming.”

David reached for his coffee mug. It was the one Akudo had chipped against the kitchen sink two years earlier. They had meant to replace it, but he preferred the familiar handle.

He stopped when he saw the open cupboards.

“Mom. You moved the pots again.”

“I arranged them properly.”

“They were already arranged.”

“Then why was I searching for the big pot yesterday?”

“Because you didn't know where we kept it.”

Nwagaga considered this.

“My son, are you saying I should leave something in the wrong place because everybody is accustomed to finding it there?”

“I’m saying it wasn’t in the wrong place for us.”

She turned back to the kettle. “Drink your coffee. It will soon become cold.”

David opened the cupboard where the mugs had stood for years. It contained bowls now. He shut it, found another mug beside the plates, and returned to the coffee machine without speaking.

Having Nwagaga in the apartment was already making a difference. Akudo had slept for longer than she had since coming home from the hospital, and there had been food waiting whenever she was hungry. David was grateful for both things.

But he missed reaching for a pot without having to discover where somebody else had put it.

“Is Akudo awake?” Nwagaga asked.

“Not yet.”

“Good. Leave her.”

She set a clean towel on the counter beside a basin she had washed and dried.

David watched her test the water from the tap.

“What are you doing?”

“Preparing warm water for your wife.”

“We have hot water in the bathroom.”

“I know, my son. I have used the bathroom.”

“I wasn’t suggesting you hadn't.”

“Then we agree.”

He drank his coffee. He had begun to recognise the difference between questions Nwagaga wanted answered and questions she had already answered for herself.

When he left for the sitting room, she carried the basin toward the bathroom, taking care not to spill the water over its rim.

Akudo woke at seven twenty-four.

For several seconds, she remained beneath the sheet, listening. She could hear the faint clink of a spoon from the kitchen, the air conditioner, and a car starting somewhere in the apartment car park. Kamsi was making small noises in his bassinet, his arms moving beneath the light blanket.

She checked on him before reaching for her phone.

Three work emails had arrived overnight. One was from a colleague asking where she'd saved a file; another concerned a meeting she had helped organise before going on leave. The third had a subject line that made her stomach tighten.

She opened it.

Her maternity leave had begun, but the work she had been responsible for had not disappeared. She knew someone else was handling it. She also knew that before Kamsi's birth, she had been the person everyone approached when something went wrong.

She was reading the second paragraph when Nwagaga appeared in the doorway.

“Ị bọọla chi?” she asked. “Did you sleep well?”

“Ụtụtụ ọma, Mom.”

Nwagaga noticed the phone.

“What is that?”

“My phone.”

“I can see it is your phone. What are you doing on it?”

“Checking something from work.”

“Does your manager know you have just given birth?”

“Of course.”

“Did you give birth to a laptop?”

Despite herself, Akudo nearly laughed.

“Mom, please.”

“Did your manager follow you to the hospital?”

“No.”

“Then why is the manager following you into your bedroom?”

Akudo locked the screen.

“It's one email.”

“Yesterday it was one email. Today it is another one. By Monday you will tell me you are attending a meeting.”

“That isn't fair.”

Nwagaga stepped farther into the room. “I came so you could rest.”

“And I appreciate it. But you don't have to decide every single thing I do.”

Her mother set the towel on the chair.

“I am not deciding everything. I am asking you to put down the phone.”

“You're telling me to put it down.”

“Because you won't do it yourself.”

Akudo sat upright, careful of the soreness that still reminded her how recently she had given birth.

“Mom, I know you're trying to help. But I'm thirty-two years old. I have a husband, a job, and my own home. You can't come here and start running everything.”

The words sounded sharper in the bedroom than they had in her head.

Nwagaga drew herself up.

“Your own home. I see. ”

“That isn't what I meant.”

“It is what you said.”

“I meant I need you to ask me before you move my things or tell me what to do.”

“I have been here one day, Akudo. One day.”

“And already David can't find his own coffee mugs.”

Nwagaga turned toward the hallway. The basin was ready, and breakfast still needed preparing. She could have answered her daughter with a dozen examples of things she had done since arriving, but she kept those examples to herself.

“Your water is in the bathroom,” she said. “It is comfortably warm. Use it if you want.”

“Mom.”

“I will be in the kitchen.”

She left before Akudo could decide whether to apologise or continue the argument.

Akudo held the phone in her lap. The email was still there, waiting to be answered, but she found she had no desire to read it again.

She placed it face down on the bedside table.

In the bathroom, Nwagaga had arranged a clean basin, a towel, fresh clothes, and the soap Akudo liked. Everything was within reach. Akudo dipped her fingers into the water and found it pleasantly warm.

When she was a child, her mother had prepared water for her after school during the harmattan, when the evenings grew dry and cold. Akudo remembered coming home with dusty socks and complaining that the wind had found its way into her bones. Nwagaga would tell her to wash first and complain afterwards. Somehow, by the time she finished, there would be food on the table.

Akudo stayed in the bathroom longer than she needed to. The warm water eased some of the stiffness in her shoulders, and she was grateful for the clean clothes laid out where she could reach them.

She wished she had managed to say that without making her mother feel unwelcome.

When she returned to the bedroom, Nwagaga was sitting beside the bassinet with a little white shirt across her knees. She held it up and examined the sleeves.

“Who made this thing?”

Akudo recognised the shirt. “What is wrong with it?”

“Even a chicken would complain if you put this on it.”

“Mom, it's a newborn shirt.”

“And this boy has more clothes than some adults.”

Nwagaga folded it and placed it with the others.

For a while, neither mentioned the argument.

“I used the water,” Akudo said.

“I heard you.”

“Thank you for preparing it.”

Nwagaga picked up another shirt.

“You should eat before the morning finishes.”

Akudo sat on the bed. Her mother had accepted the thanks without looking up. She was still upset, and there was no point pretending otherwise.

“I'll eat,” Akudo said.

Later that morning, they prepared to bathe Kamsi.

Akudo had already laid out his towel, clean diaper, and clothes. Nwagaga tied her wrapper more securely before approaching the basin. She tested the water with her hand, and Akudo checked it too. At the hospital, a nurse had shown them how to keep a newborn

supported during bathing, and Akudo had been nervous about trying it without somebody beside her.

“Give him to me,” Nwagaga said.

“Here you go. You can have him.”

“Good.”

Nwagaga supported Kamsi's head with one hand and kept her other hand along his back while washing him. His legs drew up as his feet touched the comfortably warm water.

“In some families, we used to speak of pressing a baby's body,” Nwagaga said. “Your grandmother showed me what the women did in her time.”

“Did she do it with all of us?”

“She had her ways. But we are following what your nurse taught you. Hold him securely. Don't force his arms or legs.”

“And no hot water.”

“No hot water for this small boy.”

Kamsi made a brief complaint, then quieted as Nwagaga adjusted her grip. She kept one hand firmly supporting him as she rinsed and dried him. The bath was soon finished, and Nwagaga laid him on his towel.

“Well done, Mom,” Akudo said.

Nwagaga glanced at her daughter.

There was no teasing in the words.

“Thank you.”

Akudo passed her the clean diaper.

They dressed Kamsi together. When the little white shirt proved difficult to pull over his arms, Nwagaga held it up again.

“I still say this tailor does not know babies.”

“It came from a shop, Mom.”

“Then the shop should meet one.”

Akudo fastened the last button.

The small exchange helped, though it did not erase what had happened that morning.

A little later that morning, Kamsi was awake and hungry.

Akudo settled into the chair near the bedroom window. She had fed him not long before, and she was surprised that he wanted milk again

so soon. Nwagaga remained nearby, folding the last of the clean clothes while Akudo tried to remember what the nurse had said about newborn feeding.

“Are you sure he's hungry?” Akudo asked.

“Let's see what he needs.”

“His diaper is clean.”

“Then offer him milk.”

“He ate an hour ago.”

“My daughter, babies did not attend the meeting where adults agreed that people should eat only at certain times.”

Akudo adjusted Kamsi against her, and he settled to feed. She could feel the tension in her shoulders beginning to ease.

Nwagaga continued folding. The little clothes made a soft pile beside her, each shirt and pair of socks so small that she could fit several into one hand.

Akudo watched her for a while.

“When I was at the hospital,” she said, “everybody kept explaining what to do. The nurse would show me something, and I'd think I understood it. Then Kamsi would cry, and I couldn't remember any of it.”

“You remember more than you think.”

“What if I miss something important?”

Nwagaga put the socks aside.

“If he seems unwell, we call the nurse or doctor. You have their number.”

“I know.”

“You can ask questions. You do not have to guess.”

Akudo studied Kamsi's face while he fed. His fingers had curled around the edge of her shirt.

“I keep checking whether he's breathing.”

Nwagaga moved her chair closer.

“I noticed.”

“Sometimes he sleeps so quietly.”

“Did the nurse explain what to watch for?”

“Yes.”

“Then follow that advice. And if something troubles you, wake David or call for help.”

Akudo nodded. The phone conversation she had been avoiding suddenly seemed ridiculous beside the concerns she was willing to admit here. Yet she could not simply stop thinking about work or the ordinary routines that had filled her life before Kamsi arrived.

“I used to be good at things,” she said.

“You still are.”

“I mean, I knew what I was doing. At work, if somebody asked me a question, I usually had an answer. Now I spend half the day wondering whether I've dressed my own son properly.”

Nwagaga studied the tiny socks in her hands.

“When I had my first child, I used to ask questions too,” she said.

Akudo turned toward her. “You?”

“Why not me?”

“You always seem to know what you're doing.”

“I have had many years to learn.”

She returned the socks to their pile. For an instant her attention seemed to be somewhere beyond the bedroom window, but when Akudo spoke again, she was listening.

“What was it like for you?”

Nwagaga took her time before answering.

“Your grandmother came to stay. She cooked and helped with the baby. I remember she would send visitors away if they arrived when I needed sleep. Your father once invited three people over when I was exhausted. She stood at the door and asked whether they had brought food or had come to eat ours.”

“What did they do?”

“They went home.”

Akudo could picture her grandmother standing in the doorway, one hand on her waist, sending grown people away without worrying whether they would be offended.

“Ǹmá really did that?”

“Of course. Your grandmother had no patience for visitors who came only to admire a baby.”

Kamsi finished feeding. Akudo shifted him carefully and settled back in the chair, feeling the heaviness of the morning catch up with her.

“I wish I could stop worrying,” she said.

Nwagaga reached for the folded towel beside her.

“Akudo, I cannot promise that you will never worry about your child. I can help you get some rest, and I can remind you to call the doctor when you need advice.”

Akudo tried to answer, but her eyes filled with tears before the words came. She was embarrassed by how suddenly it happened. She wiped her cheek with the back of her hand and looked away.

Nwagaga offered her the towel.

“Ndo, nwa m.”

“I'm sorry.”

“What are you apologising for?”

Akudo shook her head. She had already spent the morning snapping at her mother and now found herself crying in front of her.

“I'm tired. I love him so much, and sometimes I just want to sleep. Then I feel terrible for wanting that.”

Nwagaga pulled the other chair close enough to sit beside her.

“You've been awake for three nights, my daughter.”

“Everybody says I should enjoy every moment.”

“Everybody is not the one sitting here.”

Akudo held the towel against her eyes. Her mother stayed beside her while she cried, without insisting on another explanation.

After a while, Nwagaga spoke.

“Let David take care of the washing today. I'll make lunch. When Kamsi has finished feeding, you can lie down.”

“And what if he wakes?”

“We will hear him.”

Akudo knew she would still listen for every noise, but the thought of closing her eyes without being responsible for everything in the apartment was a relief.

She leaned against her mother's shoulder for a little while. Nwagaga kept her hand on the back of the chair, allowing her daughter to remain there until she was ready to sit upright again.

David came back from the supermarket shortly before noon.

He had bought bread, eggs, fruit, and most of the things on Nwagaga's handwritten list. He had also chosen a packet of biscuits Akudo liked, although nobody had requested them.

Nwagaga inspected the bags while he unpacked them.

“Where is the ginger?”

David stopped.

He checked one bag, then the other.

“I forgot it.”

“Chineke.”

“I can go back.”

“No. We have enough for today.”

He put the remaining groceries away, opening a cupboard before remembering that the shelves had been rearranged. A bag of rice slipped against a stack of bowls and made him grab for both.

“Mom,” he said, “can we please leave the cupboards where they are now?”

Nwagaga straightened.

“I only moved a few things.”

“I know. But I live here. I need to find things when I get up in the night.”

“You can ask me.”

“I shouldn't have to wake you to find a mug.”

Akudo was at the dining table with a bowl of pap and a boiled egg. She had been listening while they spoke, and David's irritation was plain enough that she did not try to turn it into a joke.

Nwagaga folded the shopping list.

“I didn't know it troubled you that much.”

“It does. The help is good, Mom. We need it. But some things are ours to decide.”

Nwagaga placed the list beside the kettle.

“Very well. Show me where the things used to be, and we can put them back.”

“Thank you.”

David carried the empty bags to the cupboard near the door. He was still annoyed, even after she agreed. Akudo understood why. She had spent the morning trying to explain almost the same thing.

When he returned to the table, he found the biscuits beside her bowl.

“For you,” he said.

“You remembered.”

He pulled out the chair opposite her.

“Someone in this apartment still knows where things belong.”

Akudo reached for a biscuit without answering. She could hear Nwagaga moving quietly around the kitchen behind them.

Later, while David dealt with the laundry, Akudo sat beside her mother in the bedroom to fold Kamsi's clothes.

For several minutes, they worked without speaking. Nwagaga made neat piles on the bed, and Akudo matched the little socks, turning one pair over twice before finding its partner.

“Did Ǹmá teach you everything about Omugwo?” Akudo asked.

“Not everything. She taught me what she knew. Other women taught me things too.”

“Was she always so sure of herself?”

Nwagaga ran her thumb along the seam of a little shirt.

“No. But she preferred people to think so.”

Akudo glanced at her. That answer was more interesting than the stories of Ǹmá driving visitors away.

“Did she ever admit she was wrong?”

“Sometimes. After everybody else had grown tired of arguing.”

That sounded familiar.

Akudo lifted a pair of socks from the pile. As Nwagaga reached for them, she noticed a pale scar across one of her mother's knuckles.

“Mom, where did you get that?”

Nwagaga turned her hand over.

“This?”

“Yes.”

“An old accident.”

“What happened?”

For a while, Nwagaga examined the scar as though she had not noticed it in years.

“Your younger sister was about five or six. Do you remember the afternoon she refused to go outside with the other children?”

Akudo remembered a courtyard in Nigeria, the hot ground beneath her sandals, and her sister standing near the doorway crying while the other children called for her to come and play.

“She kept saying somebody would get hurt,” Akudo said.

“Yes.”

“One of the boys fell near the back steps.”

“I was rushing to help him. That's how I injured my hand.”

“He was all right, wasn't he?”

“He recovered.”

Akudo put down the socks. She had remembered the fall many times, usually because of the way the adults hurried toward the steps. She had not connected it with the scar on her mother's hand.

“Ǹmá was frightened that day,” she said.

“She was.”

“Because my sister said something before it happened?”

Nwagaga folded the shirt and placed it with the others.

“Your grandmother had already lived through things that made her fearful.”

“The family promise?”

Her mother did not dispute it.

Akudo felt the old irritation returning. Last night, Nwagaga had promised that they would talk properly today. Now the answer was another sentence that explained very little.

“Mom, you said we would talk.”

“I remember.”

“It's Friday. This is tomorrow.”

“I know what day it is, Akudo.”

“Then why are we still circling around it?”

Nwagaga put the last shirt aside.

“I should not have promised that everything could be told in one morning.”

“You promised to stop keeping it from me.”

“Yes.”

Akudo waited. Nwagaga looked toward the guest-room door and remained seated.

“The scar is from helping a boy who fell,” she said. “Your sister was frightened before it happened. Your grandmother believed it meant more than an ordinary coincidence. That is what I can tell you about that day.”

“And the letter?”

“I will give you the letter, Akudo. I am asking for a little more time before we open that part of the past.”

“You've had years.”

The words were true, and Akudo did not take them back.

Nwagaga's hand closed around the edge of the folded wrapper on her lap. She rose from the bed and carried the clothes toward the wardrobe.

“I have,” she said.

Akudo stayed where she was.

It would have been easier if her mother had argued or dismissed her question. Instead, she had agreed and gone on putting away baby clothes.

* * *

That afternoon, Akudo finally slept for almost two hours.

She had fed Kamsi and settled him safely in his bassinet before lying down. David remained nearby while Nwagaga returned to the kitchen. Akudo woke once at a distant sound, realised that David was awake, and fell asleep again.

When she opened her eyes properly, the light had shifted across the bedroom floor.

She checked the clock and hurried toward the sitting room.

David was sitting near the bassinet, reading something on his phone. He put it aside when he saw her.

“Hey. You slept.”

“How long?”

“Almost two hours.”

“And Kamsi?”

“Fed, changed, and now asleep. Mom helped.”

Akudo went to the bassinet. Her son was resting comfortably, one hand beside his cheek.

“Why didn't you wake me?”

“Because you were exhausted.”

She sat beside David.

“I heard what you said about the kitchen.”

“I didn't mean to argue with her.”

“You weren't wrong.”

“I know she's trying to help. And she has helped. But it feels strange having somebody decide where everything goes.”

Akudo reached for his hand.

“I told her the same thing this morning. Less politely.”

David glanced toward the kitchen. Nwagaga was rinsing something at the sink, beyond the half-open doorway.

“She'll be upset for a while.”

“Probably.”

“Are you going to apologise?”

“For how I said it, yes. Not for wanting to be asked first.”

David leaned back against the sofa. He had been on his feet most of the day, and the tiredness showed around his eyes.

“That sounds fair.”

Akudo rested her head against his shoulder. They sat there without trying to solve the disagreement before Nwagaga came out of the kitchen.

After a while, David turned and kissed her forehead.

“There's water beside your chair,” he said. “Drink some before Mom discovers you haven't.”

Akudo reached for the glass.

From the kitchen came the sound of a cupboard opening, followed by a pause. Nwagaga had found something in a place she did not expect.

She closed the cupboard again.

Akudo could have called out to tell her where the cooking spoons were. Instead, she took another drink of water and listened to her mother search.

Chapter Four: The Pot

Later that Friday afternoon, the smell of pepper soup had reached the hallway.

Nwagaga stood at the stove with her wrapper tied firmly around her waist, a wooden spoon in one hand and the lid of a large pot in the other. Steam rose against the kitchen cabinets whenever she lifted the lid. The air conditioner worked steadily, but the apartment still carried the warmth of cooking, along with the scents of smoked fish and spices she had brought from Nigeria.

Akudo sat at the dining table with a glass of water. She had promised herself she would stay out of the kitchen while her mother cooked, partly because she needed to rest and partly because neither of them had entirely recovered from their disagreement that morning.

David was rinsing the last of the dishes.

“Mom,” Akudo said, “that pepper is reaching all the way here.”

Nwagaga stirred the pot.

“Who told you to come and smell it?”

“I didn't come anywhere. I'm sitting in my own dining room.”

“Then remain there and allow the cook to work.”

David turned off the tap. “I think the neighbours can smell it too.”

“Good. Let them know somebody has entered this kitchen.”

He dried his hands on a towel and gave Akudo a glance. She knew what he was thinking. Nwagaga had rearranged the kitchen twice since arriving, and neither he nor Akudo had agreed that the second arrangement was an improvement.

That morning, though, Nwagaga had asked David where he wanted the cooking spoons. He had shown her. She had put them back without delivering a speech about the proper arrangement of utensils.

It was progress, although nobody had said so aloud.

The soup was nearly ready. Goat meat simmered in a broth fragrant with ehuru, uda, and uziza. Nwagaga had added onions, pepper, a little crayfish, and dried fish, with scent leaves near the end of cooking. On the next burner, white yam boiled in a smaller pot, its pale pieces just beginning to soften.

Akudo watched her mother taste a spoonful of the broth.

“You didn't measure any of those spices.”

“I measured.”

“With what?”

“My eyes.”

“Mom.”

“My daughter, if I cook with my eyes for thirty years, must I suddenly begin counting teaspoons because I have reached Houston?”

“I'd like to make it myself one day.”

“Then come and learn. I cannot send measurements through the air.”

Akudo pushed back her chair and stood slowly. Her body still reminded her of the birth whenever she moved too quickly, and she was grateful when David pulled the chair aside for her without making a fuss. Nwagaga made room beside the stove.

“First, taste,” she said.

She poured a little broth into a spoon and allowed it to cool before handing it to Akudo. The pepper reached the back of Akudo's throat almost immediately.

“That is strong.”

“Is it bad?”

“No.”

“Then tell me what it needs.”

“Less pepper.”

“That is not something I can remove now.”

“Exactly.”

Nwagaga took back the spoon. “When you make your own, start with less. You can always add.”

David leaned against the counter.

“Can I write that down? It sounds like useful advice.”

“You may also write down that the goat meat must become tender before you rush the soup,” Nwagaga told him. “And the leaves should not cook until they forget their own smell.”

He picked up a pen from the counter and wrote less pepper on the back of the shopping list.

Akudo reached for it.

“Are you really taking notes?”

“Your mother has agreed to teach us. I don't want to fail the examination.”

“She will still tell you that you did it wrongly.”

“I am preparing myself.”

Nwagaga returned to the stove. “Both of you are talking too much for people who want to eat.”

Cooking had always drawn conversation out of Nwagaga.

When Akudo was growing up, she could ask her mother a question over breakfast and receive three words in reply. Ask the same question while onions were being chopped or a pot was simmering, and Nwagaga might tell a story that began before Akudo was born.

The kitchen had been the place where relatives became real to the children. A photograph on the wall might show an uncle standing proudly beside a car, but while cooking, Nwagaga would explain how the same uncle once borrowed a bicycle and returned it without the seat. Their father would protest that the story had been exaggerated, and Nwagaga would insist she had removed several details out of kindness.

Now, with David listening, Akudo asked about her grandma’s cooking.

“Do you remember how she used to chase us away from the pot?”

“Of course. You children would come to help and finish half the meat before the food reached the table.”

“I never took that much.”

“Akudo, your grandmother could count. She knew how many pieces went into her pot.”

David lifted his head. “So this is a family tradition?”

“Taking meat?” Akudo asked.

“Denying it.”

“My son,” Nwagaga said, “you married into the right house if you like stories.”

Akudo reached for a piece of boiled yam from the plate Nwagaga had set aside. Her mother noticed immediately.

“And what is that?”

“I'm tasting it.”

“Without soup?”

“I want to know if it's ready.”

“Now you are the inspector.”

Akudo put the piece on her plate and broke it with her fork. It was soft enough to eat. She took a small bite while Nwagaga spooned a little broth into a bowl.

The familiar combination brought back lunches at home, when the children would hover near the kitchen doorway because the smell of food travelled farther than any invitation. In Houston, the same spices filled a smaller space. The refrigerator hummed beside her, David's shopping list lay on the counter, and Kamsi slept in his bassinet in the sitting room.

She could almost hear Ǹmá telling the children to wash their hands before they touched anything.

“Your grandmother made us eat together when she could,” Nwagaga said, setting the bowl before her. “Even when somebody was angry.”

Akudo took a spoonful.

“Especially when somebody was angry.”

Nwagaga knew perfectly well what her daughter meant. She turned back to the stove, leaving the remark unanswered, but a few minutes later she asked Akudo to taste the soup again before adding more salt.

This time, she accepted her daughter's judgment.

Later that afternoon, a knock at the apartment door interrupted them.

David opened the door to find Mrs. Margaret Carter standing outside with a covered dish. She wore a pale-blue cardigan despite the warmth in the corridor, and a shopping bag hung from her wrist.

“Hello, David. I hope this isn't a bad time.”

“Not at all. Come in.”

Mrs. Carter stepped across the threshold and stopped when the smell of the soup reached her.

“Oh, my goodness. What are you making?”

From the kitchen, Nwagaga called, “Food!”

“That would be my mother,” Akudo said.

Mrs. Carter had lived across the hallway for nearly three years. She knew which deliveries belonged to Akudo and David, which days the rubbish was collected, and how unreliable the building's lift could be. Until that week, however, she had known little about the family beyond the occasional conversation outside their apartment.

Now she found a Nigerian grandmother standing beside a steaming pot, wearing a bright wrapper and carrying a wooden spoon as though visitors were expected.

“Hello,” Mrs. Carter said. “I'm Margaret Carter.”

Nwagaga replied, “Welcome to our home.”

“I brought some banana bread. I thought the new parents might appreciate something easy to eat.”

Akudo came closer.

“Mrs. Carter, you didn't have to do that.”

“Of course I didn't. That's why it counts as a gift.”

She handed the dish to David, who thanked her and placed it on the table.

Nwagaga drew a chair away from the dining table.

“Sit. You have brought food, so you must eat something too.”

“Oh, I really shouldn't stay.”

“Why?”

“I don't want to interrupt your lunch.”

“Then you came at a good time. We are nearly ready.”

Mrs. Carter turned to Akudo, uncertain whether she was being invited or firmly instructed.

“She's serious,” Akudo told her.

“I gathered that.”

Nwagaga took down a small soup bowl.

“Have you eaten Nigerian pepper soup before?”

“I don't believe I have.”

“Then today you will try.”

“Is it spicy?”

Akudo started to answer, but Nwagaga was already pouring a little broth into the soup bowl.

“A little.”

“Mom,” Akudo said, “your little and Mrs. Carter's little may be two different things.”

“I will give her only a taste.”

Nwagaga waited until the broth had cooled enough, then handed Mrs. Carter a spoon. Mrs. Carter tried a small amount, paused, and reached for the water David had placed beside her.

“Oh! That's got some personality.”

David took the cup before she accidentally spilled it.

“Mom, perhaps the next batch could have a little less personality.”

“The next one will be made for our visitor,” Nwagaga said. “This one is for people who know what they are eating.”

Mrs. Carter sipped her water.

“I like it, actually. I just wasn't prepared.”

“Good,” Nwagaga said. “Next time, you will be prepared.”

Akudo cut the banana bread while David carried the serving dishes to the table. Nobody made Mrs. Carter feel that she ought to leave, and within minutes she had taken off her cardigan and settled into the chair Nwagaga had chosen for her.

Mrs. Carter asked about the food first.

She wanted to know what kind of yam Nwagaga had cooked and whether pepper soup was something people ate every day. Nwagaga explained that families prepared it in different ways, using whatever ingredients they preferred or could find. The version on their table was the one she had cooked for years.

“And you're here from Nigeria to help with the baby?” Mrs. Carter asked.

“With my daughter too.”

Nwagaga pointed to Akudo's plate.

“In our family, when a woman gives birth, someone comes to help her recover and settle with the child. We call it Omugwo.”

Mrs. Carter repeated the word carefully.

“Omugwo.”

“Yes. I cook, help with the baby, wash clothes if they need washing, and make sure she has time to rest.”

“So Akudo doesn't have to do everything herself.”

“That is the idea. Though this one still thinks her office will collapse if she does not answer an email.”

“Mom,” Akudo warned.

Mrs. Carter glanced at the phone resting on the counter.

“My daughter did the same thing after her first baby,” she said. “She kept answering work messages when she should have been sleeping.”

Akudo folded her arms. “I'm beginning to feel outnumbered.”

“You are,” David said.

She turned toward him. He reached for another piece of yam, apparently satisfied that he had contributed enough to the discussion.

Mrs. Carter looked back at Nwagaga.

“How long do you stay for Omugwo?”

“It depends on the family and what is possible. Some people come for weeks. Others can only manage a few days. If a mother cannot come, another relative or trusted person may help.”

“That sounds lovely.”

“It can be,” Nwagaga said. “Provided the people involved remember whose house they are in.”

Akudo raised her eyes from her plate.

Nwagaga served herself another piece of yam without looking at her.

David concentrated on his food. The kitchen cupboards had clearly taught everybody something that morning.

“I wish I'd known more about this when my grandson was born.”

“Were you able to stay with your daughter?” Akudo asked.

“No. My husband was ill then. He needed me at home, and my daughter lived in another state.”

She set down her fork. Her husband had died some years earlier, and she rarely mentioned him without some small detail about what he had liked or how stubborn he had been.

“I remember talking to my daughter on the phone,” she continued. “She sounded exhausted. I kept telling her to sleep whenever the baby slept, as though somebody else would magically appear to wash the bottles and make dinner.”

David nodded. He had heard that advice often since Kamsi was born.

“I think people forget how much else there is to do,” he said.

“Exactly. I couldn't leave my husband, and she said she understood. But I still wish I'd thought to ask one of her friends to bring a meal or sit with her for an afternoon.”

Nwagaga moved the serving bowl nearer to Mrs. Carter.

“You were caring for somebody too. You could not leave him alone.”

“I know.”

Mrs. Carter spoke without asking anyone to reassure her. Akudo appreciated that. There were things people carried for years even when they understood there had been no better choice available to them.

Nwagaga offered her another piece of yam.

Mrs. Carter accepted half.

For the next several minutes, the conversation moved to safer ground: the price of groceries, the building's unreliable lift, the way Houston weather could change the entire day's plans, and the astonishing amount of laundry produced by a child who weighed less than most shopping bags.

Kamsi woke while David was explaining how many little shirts they had washed since bringing him home. Akudo went to him, checked that he was comfortable, and returned with him resting against her shoulder.

Mrs. Carter leaned forward.

“He's beautiful.”

“Thank you,” Akudo said.

“And how are you?”

Akudo started to answer automatically. She had been asked about the baby so often that she had almost forgotten how to respond when somebody asked about her.

“Better than yesterday,” she said.

“That's good.”

“Still tired.”

“Of course.”

Mrs. Carter moved a dish aside to make more room on the table.

“If you ever need anything from across the hall, please ask. And I mean something useful. Not just someone to admire him for five minutes.”

“I might take you up on that.”

“I hope you do.”

Nwagaga brought the remaining yam to the table. She had already eaten, but she stayed beside them while Mrs. Carter finished her lunch. When David offered to wash the dishes, she passed him the bowls and allowed him to take them without explaining how they ought to be stacked.

Akudo noticed.

She said nothing.

Mrs. Carter stayed longer than she had intended.

By the time she stood to leave, the banana bread had been cut into generous slices, David had told her more about the family's arrival surprise than Akudo thought necessary, and Nwagaga had promised to make a milder portion of pepper soup for her another day.

At the doorway, Mrs. Carter turned back to Akudo.

“There's a neighbour down the hall who recently had twins,” Mrs. Carter said. “I think I'll call her tonight and ask whether she needs anything.”

“A neighbour?”

“Yes. The woman down the hall has twins.”

Nwagaga came from the kitchen carrying the empty banana-bread dish, now washed and dried.

“Tell her to ask what the mother needs,” she said. “She may need somebody to hold the baby. Or she may need somebody to take the rubbish outside.”

Mrs. Carter accepted the dish.

“I can certainly tell her that.”

“Good. And thank you for the bread.”

“Thank you for lunch.”

After she left, David shut the door and went back to the kitchen. Akudo settled Kamsi in his bassinet and returned to the table, where the last piece of banana bread remained on a plate.

Nwagaga had started putting away the food. Instead of opening cupboards at random, she called across the room.

“David, where do you want this container?”

He showed her the shelf.

She put it there.

Akudo watched the exchange from the table. Her mother caught her expression but made no comment. She picked up the serving spoon, rinsed it, and placed it beside the sink.

“Mom,” Akudo said, “the soup was good.”

“I know.”

“And thank you for lunch.”

Nwagaga glanced toward the empty plates.

“Then tomorrow you will eat before it becomes cold.”

Akudo took the last piece of banana bread. Kamsi made a small sound from the sitting room, and David went to check on him before either woman stood.

Outside, footsteps passed along the corridor. A door opened across the hall, and Mrs. Carter's voice carried through briefly as she answered her telephone.

From the kitchen, Nwagaga asked where Akudo kept the lids for the food containers.

“Top drawer, Mom.”

There was a pause while the drawer slid open.

“Ah. So this one has a sensible place.”

Akudo bit into the banana bread.

Chapter Five: The Old Family Story

On Saturday morning, Akudo found her mother sitting at the dining table with a cup of tea she had forgotten to drink.

The apartment was unusually still. David had taken Kamsi into the sitting room after his feeding, leaving Akudo to finish her breakfast without interruption. In the kitchen, the large pepper-soup pot stood washed and drying beside the sink. Nwagaga had prepared pap earlier, but for once she had not stood over her daughter insisting she eat another spoonful.

The brown envelope lay on the table.

Akudo stopped beside her chair.

Nwagaga had placed it next to the framed photograph of her late husband. The paper was worn at the corners, and the blue handwriting was exactly as Akudo remembered from the guest room.

Her name.

For two days, the envelope had followed her through ordinary moments. While she fed Kamsi, she thought about it. While David searched for his coffee mug, she remembered the handwriting. Even yesterday, during the argument over the kitchen and her work emails, she had been aware that her mother was carrying something far more difficult than an opinion about cupboard arrangements.

Now it was in front of her.

“I was going to bring it to you after breakfast,” Nwagaga said.

Akudo pulled out her chair but remained standing.

“Why now?”

“Because I have delayed long enough.”

“That wasn't what I asked.”

Her mother reached for her tea, then left the cup untouched.

“I brought the letter because your grandmother asked me to. When I arrived, I thought I could give it to you and explain everything. But seeing Kamsi...”

She stopped and adjusted the edge of her wrapper.

“There are things I thought I had learned to speak about.”

Akudo sat opposite her.

She had waited for this conversation since Thursday, and now that her mother was finally offering it, she was frightened of what the letter might contain. Her grandmother had been dead for years. Nobody kept a letter that long, carried it across an ocean, and struggled so visibly to hand it over unless it mattered.

“Was Dad aware of the letter?” Akudo asked.

“Yes, he was.”

“And he never told me?”

“No. He didn't.”

Akudo lowered her eyes to the photograph. Her father was grinning at the camera, his shoulders turned slightly as though somebody had called him just before the picture was taken.

“He never said anything to me.”

Nwagaga did not attempt to defend him.

From the sitting room came the low murmur of David speaking to Kamsi. The baby answered with a brief, dissatisfied noise. David murmured something else, and the sound stopped.

Akudo reached for the envelope.

“I'm going to read it.”

“I know.”

“Please don't interrupt me.”

Nwagaga drew her hands into her lap.

Akudo lifted the edge of the flap. The seal had become brittle with age. She opened it carefully and removed several folded sheets of paper, with a small photograph tucked between them.

The handwriting was Ǹmá's.

She recognised the firm downward strokes, the careful spacing, and the way her grandmother had always made the first letter of a name larger than the others. As a child, Akudo had received birthday cards in that handwriting. Some contained money. Others contained instructions about reading her books and listening to her parents.

This one began differently. Akudo read her grandmother’s words:

My Akudo,

There are children in our family whom you were never told about. I am writing this because I have grown old enough to understand that keeping a thing quiet does not make it disappear.

Before your mother was born, I had a son.

Akudo stopped.

She read the sentence again.

Her grandma had told countless stories about her childhood, her marriage, and the children who filled her house. She had described Nwagaga as a girl who argued with adults and made up songs while sweeping. Never once had she mentioned a son born before her.

Akudo turned the page slightly toward the window, as if more light might change the words.

It did not. She continued reading.

He was my first child. I was young when he came, and my own mother could not be with me. I wanted her there. There were days when I needed to ask a question and had nobody I trusted to answer it. Other women helped when they could, but I missed my mother, and I was afraid of doing something wrong.

We lost our little boy while he was still a baby.

People spoke about what might have happened. Some blamed this. Others blamed that. I listened to all of them because I wanted an answer. I wanted somebody to tell me why a child we had welcomed with such joy was no longer with us.

I never received an answer I could know to be true.

Akudo lowered the paper.

Her grandmother had lost a son.

Nwagaga had grown up with the memory of a brother she never met, or perhaps with the knowledge of him spoken around her. Akudo tried to picture M̀má as a young woman. She could manage the wrapper, the cooking pots, the determined voice. It was harder to imagine the grandmother she remembered being uncertain about anything.

She looked across the table.

“You had an older brother?”

Nwagaga nodded once.

“What was his name?”

Her mother told her.

Akudo repeated it under her breath. It was the first time she had ever said her uncle's name.

“Why didn't Ǹmá tell us about him?”

“She spoke of him less as she grew older. Sometimes I think she had said everything she could bear to say. Sometimes I think the family made it easier for her not to speak.”

Akudo turned back to Ǹmá’s letter and read on.

When your mother had her first child, I went to stay with her. I cooked for her, washed clothes, helped with the baby, and sent visitors home when they had stayed too long. I remember how angry your grandfather was when I told his friends that a woman who had just given birth was entitled to sleep.

Akudo could almost hear Ǹmá saying it.

The familiar humour lasted only a few lines.

Her first child was a boy too.

Akudo's fingers tightened around the paper.

She read the next lines of her grandmother’s letter.

He was loved. Your mother loved him from the moment she first held him, and I loved him because he was hers. We cared for him as best we knew. I was there with her during Omugwo. She was not left alone.

Still, we lost him.

There are things a family can do for a new mother. There are meals to cook, clothes to wash, and hours of sleep to protect. There is comfort in having somebody beside you. But love and care do not allow us to control every sorrow that enters a home.

We never knew with certainty why either boy died.

Akudo set the pages on the table.

For several seconds she heard nothing except the refrigerator. She was aware of the chair beneath her and the warm cup of tea near her elbow, but the ordinary things in the room seemed strangely distant.

Her mother had another child before her.

A son.

An older brother she had never known existed.

She turned toward the sitting room. David was still there with Kamsi, his voice carrying through the doorway. He had no idea what she had just learned.

“I had a brother,” Akudo said.

Nwagaga looked down at her hands.

“Yes.”

“A brother.”

“Yes, my first child and a boy.”

Akudo stood.

She walked to the kitchen, stopped beside the counter, and looked at the familiar row of cupboards. On Thursday, Nwagaga had moved the pots. Yesterday, David had insisted on putting some of them back. There was a faint water mark on the counter where somebody had left a glass without a coaster.

Akudo had lived with her mother for most of her childhood. She had heard the stories about relatives, listened to arguments at Christmas gatherings, and asked questions about the family photographs. There had always been room for another story at the dinner table.

But nobody had told her she had once had an older brother.

She returned to the table.

“Did my elder brother have a name?”

“Of course.”

“Then why have I never heard it?”

Nwagaga answered her, and this time Akudo let the name remain between them.

“Did you have a photograph of him?”

Her mother touched the envelope.

“Read the rest first.”

Akudo wanted to refuse. She was tired of instructions, tired of discovering that other people had decided which parts of her own family history she was allowed to know.

But she took up the pages and returned to Ǹmá’s words.

> You may have heard the story of Nnenna, the woman from our family who went looking for protection for her first child. Some relatives believed she made a promise that concerned the firstborn children who would come after her.
>
> I heard that story when I was young. After my son died, it frightened me. After your mother lost her son, it frightened me even more.
>
> Your grandfather believed we had neglected the old promise. Your father later heard what happened in our family and feared it too. I cannot tell you that either child died because of a promise made generations before. I had no proof of that, yet there were years when I behaved as though I did.

When something bad happened, I remembered the promise. When nothing happened, I rarely thought of it. That is how fear worked on me.

Akudo stopped to straighten the pages.

She remembered the afternoon Nwagaga had described yesterday: her younger sister refusing to leave the house, a boy falling near the back steps, adults rushing across the courtyard. Ǹmá's frightened face had remained in Akudo's memory long after the boy recovered.

The next passage in the letter brought back another recollection.

When you were little and became ill, I was afraid that the old trouble had found its way to you. I wanted the elders to perform a protective ritual. I took you to the family home without telling your mother everything I intended.

Your mother arrived before it happened. She took you home.

I was angry with her. I told myself she was refusing protection that older people understood better than she did. But she was your mother, and she had every right to decide what was done to her child.

I have regretted that day.

Akudo remembered being taken to the family compound. She had never understood why the adults spoke in lowered voices or why Nwagaga arrived looking as though she had hurried there.

She remembered being lifted into the car.

She remembered asking for her shoes.

Nobody had explained anything.

Your younger sister sometimes said things that frightened the family. Some of them appeared to come true. Others did not. In my fear, I gave the frightening ones more importance than they deserved.

I am sorry for the burden I placed on your mother. I am sorry I allowed my own grief to decide what I believed you needed.

If you become a mother one day, I hope there will be somebody beside you to help you rest and care for your child. I hope you will have the kindness of Omugwo without carrying the fear I carried.

The boys we lost were children we loved. Please remember them as part of our family. Do not let anybody turn their lives into evidence of a curse.

Love,

Your grandmother.

Akudo reached the end of Ǹmá's letter and lowered the pages.

The photograph lay between the folded pages.

She took it out.

It showed Nwagaga as a young woman seated in a wooden chair, holding a baby wrapped in a light cloth. Her hair was arranged differently, and she looked younger than Akudo had ever seen her in person. The photograph had faded around the edges, but her mother's face was clear.

On the back, Ǹmá had written a date and a few words identifying the child.

Your mother and her first son.

Akudo placed the photograph on the table.

Until that morning, she had believed she was her mother's firstborn. She had heard the old family story and wondered what it meant for her. Now she understood that another child had come before her, a brother whose existence had been kept from her. Whatever the relatives believed about firstborn children, they had allowed her to grow up without knowing where she stood in her own family.

And Kamsi was her firstborn son.

The thought made her grip the edge of the table.

Her grandmother's letter had explained why the family had been afraid. It had not given her any reason to believe that fear should govern her son's life.

"Does David know about my brother?" she asked.

"He knows I lost a child before you. I told him before Kamsi was born."

Akudo looked up.

"You told David?"

"He is your husband. I thought he should understand why I was worried."

"And you didn't think I should understand?"

Nwagaga opened her mouth, but Akudo continued.

"He knows something about my life that I don't know. You told him, and I was the one who grew up in your house."

"I asked him not to tell you until I had spoken with you."

“So you made him part of the secret too.”

Her mother did not deny it.

Akudo pushed the photograph away from herself.

She was angry with Nwagaga. Angry with her father, who had died without mentioning the brother she never knew. Angry with her grandmother, whose letter had given her so much and left her no opportunity to ask questions. Even the ordinary sounds of the apartment irritated her. David was moving something in the sitting room, and a cupboard door closed with a sharp click.

“Why?” she asked.

Nwagaga had an answer ready, but Akudo raised her hand.

“Please don't tell me it was to protect me. You have said that already.”

Her mother let the words go.

Akudo waited.

“When you were born,” Nwagaga said eventually, “people wanted me to be happy. They wanted me to leave what happened behind and concentrate on the child in my arms.”

“But you couldn't.”

“No.”

“Did you want to talk about him?”

“Sometimes. Other times I couldn't bear hearing his name.”

Akudo looked at the photograph again.

“I would have listened.”

“I know that now.”

“You could have told me when I was older.”

“I could have.”

“When Dad was alive.”

“Yes.”

Akudo pressed her lips together. Every answer made the silence of the past seem more deliberate.

She picked up the photograph and turned it over. The date was still there, written in ink that had begun to fade.

“Did you keep anything else of his?”

“A few things.”

“Where?”

“At home in Nigeria.”

“Will you show me?”

Nwagaga's hands moved toward the photograph, then stopped.

“If you want to see them.”

“Of course I want to see them. He was my brother.”

Nwagaga lowered her head.

Akudo had expected her mother to argue, perhaps to say that the past was painful or that some things were better left alone. She had prepared herself for another struggle.

Instead, Nwagaga reached for her handkerchief.

Akudo sat back in her chair.

For years she had known her mother as the woman who could settle an argument about food, arrange a household in an afternoon, and walk into an unfamiliar kitchen as though she had always belonged there. She knew Nwagaga could be stubborn. She knew she could be exhausting. It had never occurred to Akudo that there were questions her mother feared so much she could hardly answer them.

That knowledge did not make Akudo less angry.

It made the anger more difficult to carry.

David appeared in the dining-room doorway when Kamsi began fussing.

“Love? I think he’s hungry,” David said.

She folded the letter carefully and slipped the photograph between its pages.

“I'll come.”

David noticed the envelope on the table. His expression changed, but he said nothing.

Akudo went past him into the sitting room and lifted Kamsi from his bassinet. His tiny mouth moved against her shirt as she settled into the chair. She had fed him earlier, but he was ready again.

David brought her a glass of water.

“Thank you.”

He placed it beside her and stood there for a moment.

“You read it?”

“Yes.”

He sat on the opposite side of the room.

“Your mom wanted to tell you herself.”

“I know.”

“She was worried.”

“I know that too.”

Akudo adjusted Kamsi in her arms.

David waited. His decision to keep Nwagaga's confidence had seemed reasonable when they discussed it, but he could see now how differently Akudo understood that decision.

“You should have told me,” she said.

“I thought it belonged to her to tell.”

“And now?”

“Now I wish I'd asked her to speak to you sooner.”

Akudo looked down at Kamsi.

She was too tired to argue with David as well. He had stayed beside her through the long nights after the birth, brought her water when she forgot to drink, and done all the small tasks she had not noticed until they were finished. She did not doubt his intentions.

But his silence had hurt.

“I need some time,” she said.

David nodded.

“Okay.”

He went into the kitchen, leaving her with the baby.

Kamsi fed quietly. The curtains moved a little beneath the air conditioner, and sunlight spread across the rug. From the hallway came the sound of Nwagaga opening and closing a drawer in the guest room.

Akudo thought of the photograph.

Her mother had once sat with another baby boy in her arms, just as Akudo was sitting with Kamsi now. The picture was so ordinary. A chair, a child, a young woman's face. Akudo wondered who had taken it and whether Nwagaga had been pleased with the photograph when she first saw it.

She wanted to know what her brother had been like. Whether he had cried often. Whether he had his mother's eyes. Whether anybody had ever noticed that his hands looked like the hands of another child born years later.

Kamsi released his hold and began to drift toward sleep.

Akudo kept him close for another minute before settling him safely in the bassinet.

* * *

The rest of the afternoon passed unevenly.

Nwagaga cooked rice and warmed some stew from the previous day. She put a plate aside for Akudo without asking whether she was hungry. David folded the clean baby clothes in the bedroom. Nobody mentioned the envelope.

At one point, Akudo went into the kitchen for water and found her mother standing beside the stove with the spoon resting against the pot.

“Did he look like me?” Akudo asked.

Nwagaga understood immediately.

“Your brother?”

“Yes.”

“He had your father's nose.”

Akudo waited.

“And your eyes,” Nwagaga added. “When you were small, sometimes I would see the two of you together in my mind. It could happen when you were sleeping, or when you turned your head a certain way.”

Akudo put the glass on the counter.

“Did that make you sad?”

“Sometimes.”

“Did it make you happy?”

Nwagaga considered the question.

“Sometimes, too.”

Akudo wanted to say something about how strange it was that a person could miss someone and love the child standing in front of them at the same time. Instead, she watched her mother take the spoon from the counter and stir the rice.

There would be other questions.

She left the kitchen without asking another one.

Later, David took Kamsi for a short walk around the apartment while Akudo rested on the sofa. She could hear him naming the rooms as they passed them, showing the baby the window, the television, and the photograph on the shelf. Kamsi could not understand any of it, but David appeared satisfied with the tour.

Nwagaga sat at the dining table with her tea.

The opened envelope remained between them.

Akudo looked at it from the sofa.

“Mom.”

“Yes, nwa m?”

“I don't know what to do with all of this yet.”

“You don't have to decide today.”

Akudo was grateful her mother had not asked for forgiveness. She was not ready to offer it.

Outside, somebody started a car. The engine ran for a while before the vehicle moved away. From the kitchen came the faint smell of rice beginning to catch at the bottom of the pot.

Nwagaga rose to lower the heat.

Akudo watched her go, then turned the photograph over once more.

She held it until the light from the window began to fade.

Chapter Six: The Song Mom Sang

At eleven forty-three on Saturday night, Kamsi decided that nobody in the apartment had earned the right to sleep.

He had eaten. His diaper was clean. Akudo had held him against her shoulder, walked the length of the bedroom, and tried to sing the little songs she remembered from childhood. Each time his eyelids began to close, she lowered him into the bassinet. Each time, he objected.

David stood beside the bed in yesterday's T-shirt, watching his son with the concentration of a man trying to understand instructions written in a language he had never studied.

“Maybe he wants somebody to carry him,” he suggested.

Akudo turned.

“David. What have I been doing for the past hour?”

“Carrying him.”

“And before that?”

“Also carrying him.”

“Good. I wanted to be sure we were in the same room.”

He held out his arms. “Give him to me.”

She passed Kamsi over and sat on the edge of the bed. Her shoulders hurt. She had spent much of the day feeding the baby, answering questions she had never imagined needing to ask, and trying to decide whether she was angrier with her mother or her husband.

The letter was no longer on the dining table. She had carried it to the guest room after supper, unable to bear seeing it beside the dishes. Its words remained with her all the same.

David settled Kamsi against his chest.

“Hello, Henry. It's your father again. We met earlier.”

Kamsi continued complaining.

“I know. You weren't impressed then either.”

Akudo pressed her palms against her eyes.

“Please tell him I have resigned.”

“From motherhood?”

“From the night shift.”

David walked toward the window, turned carefully, and came back. Kamsi's cries grew louder.

“Your resignation hasn't been accepted,” David said.

From the hallway came the sound of slippers.

Nwagaga appeared in the doorway, fastening her wrapper at the waist. She had changed into an old blouse and covered her hair with a scarf, but her expression suggested she had been expecting to find them both awake.

“What is happening to my grandson?”

“He has a complaint,” David said. “He refuses to explain it.”

Nwagaga came closer.

“Is this the same child you people were praying for?”

“Yes, Mom,” Akudo said. “And we are still grateful. We would simply like him to sleep.”

“Have you checked his diaper?”

“Yes.”

“Fed him?”

“Yes.”

“And he still wants to complain?”

David shifted the baby in his arms.

“Apparently.”

“Let me carry him for a little while.”

Kamsi made another protest as David transferred him to his grandmother. Nwagaga checked his position, supported him securely, and settled into the rocking chair beside the window.

The chair had come from a second-hand furniture shop when Akudo and David first moved into the apartment. David had spent an entire Saturday tightening its screws. It still made a faint clicking sound whenever somebody leaned too far back.

Nwagaga found its rhythm without difficulty.

“So, young man,” she told the baby, “you want the whole house to attend your meeting?”

His cries continued.

“We have heard you. You may close the meeting now.”

David stood nearby, uncertain whether he ought to offer help or leave the two of them alone. Akudo had seen him behave that way several times since Nwagaga arrived. He was willing to do almost anything, provided someone told him what needed doing. Sometimes the trouble was that two people told him different things.

Akudo lay back against the pillows. Through the bedroom window, she could see the reflection of the lamp, the dark shape of the chair, and her mother's purple wrapper. Somewhere below, a car door slammed. The air conditioner started another cycle.

Kamsi was still unsettled.

Then Nwagaga began to hum.

At first, Akudo barely noticed. The tune belonged so completely to her childhood that hearing it felt like discovering an old household object in a familiar cupboard. She knew its rise and fall before she remembered its name.

Nwagaga rocked the chair, her voice low enough that it did not compete with the baby's complaints.

Akudo turned her head.

“Mom, is that the song you used to sing when we were small?”

“Which one?”

“You know which one.”

“Then why are you asking?”

Akudo listened for another few notes.

Que Sera, Sera.

Her mother had sung it while folding clothes, washing plates, and waiting for the rain to pass. When the children were little, she sang it at bedtime too, especially on evenings when one of them refused to settle.

Akudo had never understood why Nwagaga liked that particular song. She had only known that her mother remembered it when everybody else had run out of patience.

David returned from using the restroom.

“What song is that?”

“Que Sera, Sera,” Akudo said. “Mom used to sing it to us.”

“I know that one.”

“Everybody knows it,” Nwagaga said. “But let me sing before you people begin discussing music.”

For several minutes, nobody spoke.

Kamsi's cries became less frequent. Nwagaga continued humming, sometimes pausing to adjust his position or check that he was comfortable. When he finally grew drowsy, she did not triumph over the parents or announce that she had discovered a special method.

She kept rocking.

Akudo watched the familiar movements of her mother's hands. Earlier that day, those hands had held an old photograph of a baby she had lost. Now they held her grandson.

She wanted to ask whether Nwagaga had sung the same tune to her first son.

The question remained unspoken.

David gathered the clothes they had used during the evening and carried them to the laundry basket. He checked the supply of clean diapers and brought a bottle of water to Akudo's bedside. Then he took the little pile of dry baby clothes from the chair and began folding them.

He was particularly bad at the smallest shirts. The sleeves kept disappearing into the body of the garment, and one outfit looked like a crumpled handkerchief by the time he finished.

Nwagaga watched him for a while.

“My son, what did that shirt do to you?”

David examined it.

“Nothing yet.”

“Then why are you fighting it?”

“I'm folding it.”

“Ah.”

He unfolded the shirt and tried again. This time, he spread it on the bed, smoothed the sleeves, and folded the sides inward.

“Better?”

Nwagaga inspected his work from the rocking chair.

“It will do.”

“High praise.”

“Don't let it enter your head.”

Akudo pulled the sheet higher over her legs. She had been grateful for David's help long before Nwagaga arrived, but it had become more visible lately. There were fewer dishes in the sink, fewer piles of laundry, and a clean towel waiting whenever she needed one. Neither she nor David had mastered the new routine. At least they were no longer trying to master it alone.

David put the folded clothes into a drawer, making no comment about the fact that he had found them in the place he expected.

When he came back, he sat near Akudo.

“Do you want anything?”

“Water is fine.”

“You've got some.”

“Then I've got everything I need for now.”

He settled into the chair beside the bed, leaving a little space between them. They had spoken since the letter was opened, but only about the baby, meals, and things that needed doing.

The conversation about his keeping Nwagaga's secret was still unfinished.

After a while, he said, “I know you're angry with me.”

Akudo kept her eyes on Kamsi.

“I told you that this afternoon.”

“I know. I've been thinking about it.”

“Good.”

He accepted that without attempting to make her feel guilty for being brief.

“When your mom told me about her first son, she asked me not to tell you. I thought respecting that was the right thing.”

“And you didn't think I might have a right to know?”

“I did. But I kept thinking she'd tell you herself.”

“She had years to do that.”

“I should have asked her what she was waiting for.”

Akudo shifted against the pillows. She had spent much of the afternoon rehearsing what she wanted to say to him, and now the words she had prepared seemed unnecessary. David was not trying to persuade her that he had acted perfectly.

“I don't want you and Mom deciding what I can handle,” she said.

“I understand.”

“I mean it, David. I'm not a child because I had a baby.”

“I know.”

“Then next time, talk to me.”

He rested his hands on his knees.

“Next time, I will.”

There was no immediate embrace, no joke to rescue them from the awkwardness. David stayed beside her while Nwagaga rocked Kamsi, and after a while he got up to put the empty water glass in the kitchen.

Akudo was glad he had not tried to finish the conversation for her.

When David went to the kitchen, Nwagaga spoke without turning from the chair.

“You have eaten very little since afternoon.”

“Mom.”

“I am only saying what I noticed.”

“I'm not hungry.”

“Shall I put something aside for later?”

“Yes, please.”

Nwagaga gave a small acknowledgment and returned to humming. It was the kind of ordinary exchange they had once managed without effort. Akudo had missed it that day, although she was not ready to pretend everything between them was ordinary again.

She sat up.

“Mom, I have something to ask you.”

“You've had many questions today.”

“I still have more.”

“I expected that.”

Akudo moved to the chair beside the rocking chair. Kamsi's face was relaxed now, his little hands resting against the cloth across Nwagaga's lap. The room smelled faintly of baby soap and the clean cotton David had just put away.

“What was my brother like?”

Nwagaga's rocking slowed.

Akudo waited. She wanted an answer that belonged to a real child, not another explanation of the family promise. She had heard enough about what people believed his death meant.

“Did he cry a lot?” she asked.

“Sometimes. He liked being carried. If I put him down before he was ready, everybody knew.”

Akudo glanced at Kamsi.

“So that part runs in the family.”

“Perhaps.”

“Did Dad carry him too?”

“Of course. Your father used to walk around the room with him after supper.”

“Did he look like him?”

“He had his nose.”

“You said that earlier.”

“Then why are you making me repeat myself?”

“Because I want to hear it again.”

Nwagaga adjusted the cloth beneath Kamsi's head.

“He had your father's nose. His hair grew quickly, and he always managed to pull one hand free of whatever I wrapped around him.”

Akudo looked down at Kamsi's fingers.

“Did you take many photographs?”

“Not many. Cameras were not always around in those days. The photograph you saw was taken during a visit from your uncle.”

“Where are the others?”

“At home. There are a few. Some are not very clear.”

“I want to see them.”

“I will show you.”

Akudo folded her hands in her lap. She wished she could ask the child himself what he had been like. Instead, she had to gather him from her mother's memories, one small detail at a time.

“Was Ǹmá there when he died?”

“Yes. She had come to help me after the birth.”

“During Omugwo?”

“Yes.”

“And she stayed afterward?”

“For some time.”

Nwagaga's attention remained on the baby. She was still rocking, though the chair had nearly stopped moving.

“She cooked because I did not want to enter the kitchen. Your father had to remind me to eat. My mom would take the plate from him and stand beside me until I finished enough of it to satisfy her.”

“That sounds like her.”

“It was.”

Nwagaga paused to settle the edge of Kamsi's shirt.

“People visited. Some brought food. Some sat beside me without asking questions. Others came with advice about what I should do next, as though they could make the house return to what it had been.”

“What did you do?”

“Some days I listened. Some days I asked them to leave.”

Akudo had been expecting a long explanation. Her mother's plain answers were harder to hear.

“Did Ǹmá talk about the promise immediately?”

“No. Not at first.”

“When did she?”

“After people began saying that two boys from the same family could not have died without a reason.”

“They already had a reason to be sad.”

“Yes.”

“But they wanted another one.”

Nwagaga moved her thumb along the edge of the cloth.

“Your grandmother wanted an answer she could bear. The old story gave her one, or seemed to.”

Akudo watched the dark window. She remembered her grandmother scolding children, stirring soups, and saving the better pieces of meat for whoever had arrived late. It was difficult to imagine that woman listening to relatives who believed a tragedy was punishment for an old promise.

But she had read the letter.

“Did you ever believe it?” Akudo asked.

“There were nights when I did.”

“And now?”

“I know I lost my son. I know your grandmother lost hers. I don't know why either child died.”

Akudo could hear David rinsing a cup in the kitchen.

“That's what I want Kamsi to grow up hearing,” she said. “That we had family members we lost. Not that somebody is waiting to take him away because of a promise.”

Nwagaga looked toward her daughter.

“I won't tell him that story as though it were true.”

“You told yourself enough of it to keep my brother a secret.”

Her mother's face tightened.

“I know.”

Akudo had not meant to soften the accusation. She was glad Nwagaga understood it.

There were still questions Akudo could not ask without becoming angry again. Why had her father agreed to the silence? Why had Nwagaga told David first? What other decisions had the family made while Akudo knew nothing?

She left those questions for another day.

Nwagaga looked down at Kamsi.

“Your brother had a way of opening his eyes whenever I began to put him down,” she said. “Even if he had been sleeping.”

Akudo pulled her chair closer.

“Exactly like this one?”

“Exactly.”

For the first time that evening, Akudo could picture her brother doing something ordinary.

She wished the picture had come from a memory of her own.

David returned with a small plate of rice and stew, which he placed on the bedside table.

“Mom said you might want this later,” he told Akudo.

“I will. Thank you.”

He glanced at Kamsi.

“Still asleep?”

“For now,” Nwagaga said.

“I'd like to hold him when you're ready.”

“Bring the bassinet closer first.”

David moved it beside the rocking chair. Nwagaga rose carefully and passed Kamsi into his arms. He settled the baby against his chest, checked that his head was supported, and carried him to the bassinet

when he was ready. Kamsi stirred as David lowered him, but he remained settled.

Nwagaga watched until David had stepped back.

“There,” she said. “Everybody may try to sleep now.”

“Do we need written permission?” David asked.

“No. But I may issue it if you continue talking.”

He drew the curtains and switched off the brighter lamp, leaving the small light beside the bed.

Nwagaga remained in the rocking chair for a little longer, rubbing one hand over the place where Kamsi had rested. Akudo noticed the movement, but her mother said nothing about it.

“Mom,” Akudo asked, “did you sing that song to my brother?”

Nwagaga turned toward her.

“Yes.”

Akudo had been expecting the answer. Hearing it still unsettled her.

“Did you sing it to me afterward?”

“To you, to your sister, to your brother. You children heard it so often that one of you complained I had forgotten every other song.”

“That sounds like my sister.”

“It was your sister.”

Nwagaga reached for the edge of her wrapper and folded it over her knees. Akudo remembered hearing the song while sitting on the kitchen floor, waiting for supper. Her mother had sung it when rain struck the roof in Nigeria, and sometimes when the electricity went off and everybody gathered in the same room.

Akudo had thought the song belonged to her own childhood.

It had belonged to someone else's first.

She wanted to ask whether that made it painful for Nwagaga to sing, but she had already heard enough to know the answer might change from one day to another.

“Can you sing it again?” she asked.

Nwagaga glanced toward the sleeping baby.

“He's finally settled.”

“I know. Just a little.”

Her mother began to hum.

David sat on the edge of the bed, listening. He had heard Nwagaga sing earlier, but he knew enough now to leave his questions alone.

Akudo rested her feet on the chair's lower rung and listened until the tune ended.

Nobody spoke for a while afterward.

As Nwagaga folded the cloth she had been using, Akudo noticed the pale scar across her knuckle. The mark had been there for years, though Akudo had only recently asked how she got it.

The scar reminded her of the afternoon in Nigeria when her younger sister refused to go outside.

That memory drew Akudo back to another afternoon in Nigeria, years earlier.

A partly open bedroom door. A wooden box. Her grandmother sitting beside it with a sheet of paper in her hand.

Akudo had been young enough to believe that adults kept all their important things in boxes. Money, certificates, letters. Sometimes sweets that would be distributed only when somebody remembered the children were waiting.

She had gone looking for her mother that afternoon. From the corridor, she heard voices inside her grandmother’s room.

Nwagaga stood near the window. Her grandmother sat on the edge of the bed, turning an old paper over in her hands.

“You cannot ask me to take her there again,” Nwagaga said.

Akudo did not understand who she meant. She knew only that her mother sounded angry.

“I was frightened,” Ǹmá answered from the bed. “You know why.”

“And I am her mother.”

“I know that,” Ǹmá responded.

“Then you should have spoken to me first.”

Ǹmá put the paper down beside the wooden box. Her voice changed, and Akudo heard her begin to cry.

She had never seen her grandmother cry. Her grandmother was the woman who chased children away from cooking pots, argued with traders about prices, and demanded that everybody wash their hands before sitting at her table.

Akudo moved closer to the doorway.

A floorboard creaked beneath her foot.

Both women turned.

“Akudo!” Nwagaga called. “What are you doing there?”

“I was looking for you.”

Her grandmother wiped her face with the edge of her wrapper.

“Come here, nwa m.”

Akudo entered reluctantly. The paper lay beside the box, its writing turned downward. Her grandmother moved it out of the way and held out her hand.

“Have you eaten?”

Akudo shook her head.

“Then somebody must find you food.”

“Why were you crying, Ǹmá?”

Her grandmother took time before answering.

“Your mother and I have been arguing.”

“Are you angry with her?”

“I was.”

“And now?”

Her grandmother reached into the pocket of her wrapper and found the key to the wooden box. She placed the paper inside, turned the lock, and set the key on the bedside table.

“I still have things to say to her.”

Akudo did not know what to do with that answer.

“Are you going to send Mom away?”

“No, nwa m. This is her family too.”

Nwagaga came toward the bed.

“Akudo, go and wash your hands. I'll bring you something to eat.”

Akudo left the room. Before she reached the kitchen, she heard her mother speaking again, too low to make out the words.

She had remembered the crying for years. She had forgotten the rest.

Back in the Houston bedroom, Akudo recalled her grandmother locking the paper away.

Nwagaga was putting on her slippers.

“Mom,” Akudo said, “I remember the day you argued with Ǹmá.”

Her mother stopped.

“Which day?”

“The day I found you in her room. She was crying, and there was a wooden box on the bed.”

Nwagaga pulled the second slipper onto her foot.

“I remember.”

“Was that about the ritual?”

“Yes.”

Akudo looked toward Kamsi's bassinet. He was asleep, his small face turned to one side.

“I thought Ǹmá was angry with you.”

“She was. I was angry with her too.”

“But she was crying.”

Nwagaga rested a hand against the chair.

“Your grandmother and I loved each other. We also disagreed about things that mattered.”

Akudo remembered the way her grandmother had taken her hand and asked whether she had eaten, even while her eyes were still wet. She had been the same grandmother Akudo knew, carrying a disagreement the child could not understand.

“Did she apologise?”

“Not that day.”

“Did you?”

“Not that day either.”

Akudo turned the answer over in her mind. She had spent years remembering the scene as a frightening secret. Now she could see two women who had argued over what should happen to a child, neither willing to surrender what she believed.

She could also see her mother's decision to take her home.

Nwagaga moved toward the door.

“I left some food for you in the kitchen,” she said. “If you wake hungry, warm it.”

“Mom?”

“Yes?”

“I still have questions.”

“I know.”

Nwagaga waited, one hand on the doorframe.

Akudo almost asked another. Instead, she reached for the photograph lying beside the letter on her bedside table. Her mother's young face looked back at her from the worn paper, a baby in her arms.

“I'll ask you tomorrow.”

“All right, nwa m.”

Nwagaga went down the hallway. Her slippers made a soft sound against the floor before the guest-room door closed.

Akudo placed the photograph inside the folded letter. She did not put it back in the envelope.

David turned down the bedside lamp, and she settled against the pillow. Across the room, Kamsi moved one hand and grew still again.

The rocking chair was empty.

Chapter Seven: The Promise

On Sunday morning, Nwagaga was sitting at the kitchen table with her reading glasses halfway down her nose, sorting dried leaves into two small bowls.

David stood at the stove making scrambled eggs. The window above the sink had fogged slightly from the steam of the kettle, and someone in a neighbouring apartment was running a washing machine that made the pipes knock.

Akudo stopped in the doorway.

For the first time since her mother's arrival, she did not immediately wonder where the brown envelope was. She knew what it contained now. She had read the letter, seen the photograph, and spent most of Saturday learning things about her family that she ought to have known years earlier.

Knowing them had not made Sunday any easier.

“Good morning, Mom.”

“Ị bọọla chi, Akudo?”

“Yes. Kamsi finally slept.”

“Good. Sit down and eat something.”

“I'm going to call my sister first.”

Nwagaga stopped sorting the leaves.

“At this hour?”

“It's already afternoon in Nigeria.”

“I know the time in Nigeria, my daughter.”

“Then why are you asking?”

“Because your sister does not always answer her phone on Sundays.”

Akudo took her mobile from the counter.

“She can decide that herself.”

David glanced between them. He had been hearing versions of this argument since Thursday, but something had changed. Akudo was no longer asking permission to discuss the family's past, and Nwagaga seemed to understand that insisting would only make matters worse.

“Do you want your eggs first?” he asked.

“Save mine.”

Nwagaga removed her glasses.

“Akudo, what exactly are you going to ask her?”

“What she remembers.”

“She was very young.”

“So was I.”

Her mother returned the glasses to her nose but did not touch the leaves.

“Don't make her feel she's being examined.”

“I won't.”

Akudo left the kitchen and went into the sitting room. The bassinet stood beside the sofa, where David had placed it earlier. Kamsi was sleeping peacefully, one hand curled near his cheek.

She sat where she could see him and dialled her sister.

The call rang long enough for Akudo to imagine that Nwagaga might have been right.

Then her sister answered from Nigeria, her voice bright over the phone.

“Akudo! How is our American baby?” her sister asked.

“Sleeping.”

“Ah. So you have finally found time to call somebody who is not changing nappies,” her sister teased.

“You could have called me.”

“I did. You didn't answer.”

“That was yesterday.”

“Exactly.”

Akudo heard a door closing at the other end of the call, followed by voices. Her sister asked somebody to lower the television and returned.

“How is Mom? Has she rearranged your whole house?” her sister asked.

“Most of it.”

“I warned you.”

“I remember.”

“Did she touch your kitchen?”

Akudo glanced toward the doorway.

“Ask me a more difficult question.”

Her sister knew Nwagaga well enough to understand.

For a little while, they spoke about Kamsi's feeding, the sleepless nights, and the foods their mother had brought from Nigeria. Her sister wanted a photograph of the baby in the little blue outfit she had sent. Akudo promised to take one later.

Then she told her why she had called.

“There's something I found out yesterday.”

Her sister's voice changed.

“What happened?” her sister asked.

“Mom brought a letter from Ǹmá.”

Silence followed, interrupted by a faint noise at the other end of the line.

“Which letter?” her sister asked.

“The one she left for me.”

Akudo heard her sister moving somewhere quieter.

“Akudo, what did it say?”

So Akudo told her.

She did not read the letter aloud. She explained that their grandma had lost a baby boy before Nwagaga was born, and that Nwagaga herself had lost her first son before Akudo came along. She told her about the photograph, the old family promise, and the ritual their grandma had once wanted performed when Akudo was ill.

Her sister listened without interrupting.

When Akudo finished, the line remained silent.

“Are you there?” Akudo asked into the silence.

“Yes.”

“Did you know?”

“No.”

The answer came so quickly that Akudo believed her.

“Not even about Mom's first baby?”

“No. Akudo, are you serious?”

“I've got his photograph.”

“Mom has a photograph?”

“Yes.”

Another pause.

Their childhood home had contained photographs of cousins, visiting uncles, weddings, graduations, and people neither sister could identify. They had grown up surrounded by family history, much of it explained over cooking pots and Christmas meals.

Yet nobody had pointed to a photograph and told them they had an older brother.

“I don't understand,” her sister said.

“Neither do I.”

“Have you asked Mom why?”

“More than once.”

“And?”

“She was grieving. She didn't know how to tell us. Later, she kept putting it off.”

Her sister made a noise that Akudo recognised from childhood, the one she used when an explanation sounded insufficient but she had not yet decided how to challenge it.

“That’s a very long time to put something off,” her sister said.

“I know.”

“Are you angry?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Akudo almost smiled.

“You don't even know the whole story.”

“I know somebody should have told us we had a brother.”

Akudo held the phone more tightly.

It helped to hear somebody else say we.

They talked about their grandmother next.

“Do you remember the day you refused to go outside?” Akudo asked her sister.

“Which day?”

“The afternoon one of the older boys fell near the back steps.”

“Oh, that,” her sister replied.

“You remember?”

“Of course. Everybody shouted at me afterward.”

Akudo sat straighter.

“I thought Ǹmá was angry because you kept crying.”

“She was angry after the boy fell. Before that, she was trying to send me outside.”

“What were you afraid of?”

“I don't remember exactly.”

“Mom says you kept saying somebody would get hurt.”

Her sister was quiet.

“That's what they said I told them.”

“Isn't it what you said?”

“I might have. Akudo, I was about five.”

Akudo recalled the courtyard: the heat, children calling from the steps, her sister refusing to leave the doorway. Until now, the memory had always ended with the boy's fall and the adults rushing toward him.

Her sister remembered more.

“I hated playing near those steps,” her sister said.

“Really?”

“Yes. You remember how rough they were.”

Akudo did remember.

“Did you think somebody would fall?”

“Maybe. Or maybe I was afraid of getting pushed again. I can't tell you what I was thinking every minute when I was five.”

“But you warned them.”

“I cried because I didn't want to go outside. Later, everyone kept asking what I knew.”

“What did you tell them?”

“That I wanted to stay inside.”

Akudo pressed the phone against her ear.

She remembered how the adults had spoken about her sister afterward. Some called her unusually sensitive. Others said she sometimes knew things before they happened. The story had grown with every retelling, until the frightened child in the doorway had nearly disappeared from it.

“Did Ṁmá ask you about other things?”

“All the time for a while. Especially if I said I'd had a bad dream.”

“How did that make you feel?”

“Like I'd done something wrong.”

Akudo looked toward Kamsi. He was still asleep, undisturbed by the conversation.

“Why didn't you tell me?”

“I was a child, Akudo. I thought you knew.”

Her sister let out a breath.

“Do you remember the time I said I didn’t want Uncle to travel?” her sister asked.

“Yes.”

“Everybody remembers that because his car broke down. Nobody remembers the other times I begged somebody not to leave, and they went and came back perfectly well.”

Akudo remembered those warnings too, now that her sister mentioned them.

“Mom says Ǹmá started doubting the family story.”

“Maybe she did. But I wish she had stopped asking me those questions sooner.”

Akudo had no useful answer. Her grandmother had loved them, fed them, and defended them fiercely when other people were unkind. She had also frightened a little girl who did not understand why the adults were paying so much attention to her words.

Both things belonged to the same woman.

“I'm sorry,” Akudo said.

“What are you apologising for?”

“I didn't know.”

“Neither did I, really. Not until I grew older and started thinking about it.”

Someone called her sister's name in the background. She answered briefly and returned to the phone.

“Are you going to ask Mom about all this?” her sister asked when she returned to the phone.

“I already have.”

“And?”

“She knows she should have told us sooner.”

“Knowing isn't the same as doing.”

“No.”

Her sister was quiet for a few seconds.

“Send me the photograph,” her sister said.

“I will.”

“And don't let Mom tell you to eat before you send it.”

Akudo gave a short laugh.

“I won't.”

“Tell her I said hello.”

“I will.”

“Tell Kamsi his aunty is waiting for his photograph.”

“That message he'll receive.”

They ended the call.

Akudo remained on the sofa, her phone in her lap. Her sister had not confirmed the old family story. She had given Akudo another version of a childhood afternoon, one in which a frightened little girl had been trying to avoid a rough game.

Akudo did not know which details either of them had forgotten.

She knew only that the memory had been different for the person at its centre.

* * *

When Akudo returned to the kitchen, David was putting a plate of eggs on the table.

Nwagaga had finished sorting her leaves. One bowl was full; the other contained the pieces she did not want to use.

“Did you reach your sister?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“How is she?”

“Fine. She wants a photograph of Kamsi.”

Nwagaga reached for her tea.

“And what did she say about the past?”

Akudo sat down.

“She didn't know about our brother.”

Her mother lowered the cup.

“I thought she might not.”

“She also remembers the afternoon near the back steps differently.”

Nwagaga waited.

“She says she was frightened of the rough games outside. Maybe she warned somebody because she thought one of the children would fall.”

“That's possible.”

“She says the adults questioned her afterward until she began to feel she had done something wrong.”

Nwagaga rested her hands on the table.

“I remember your grandmother asking her questions.”

“Did you stop her?”

“Sometimes.”

“Not always?”

“No.”

Akudo took a fork from beside her plate.

Her mother had not tried to excuse herself. That was becoming a familiar feature of their conversations, and Akudo still did not know whether to find it reassuring.

“She was little, Mom.”

“I know.”

“She shouldn't have had to explain things the adults didn't understand.”

Nwagaga removed her glasses and placed them beside the bowl.

“You are right.”

Akudo ate a little of her breakfast. The eggs had gone lukewarm, but she was hungry enough not to mind.

David stayed by the sink, rinsing the frying pan. He did not interrupt. For once, there was nothing useful he could add by explaining what the family ought to think.

“Will you tell her about the photograph?” Nwagaga asked.

“I promised to send it.”

“Good.”

“She might have questions for you.”

“I expect she will.”

“You should answer them.”

“I will try.”

Akudo put down her fork.

“Mom, you keep saying you'll try.”

“Because I am not sure I will always find the right words.”

“Neither am I.”

Nwagaga's eyes moved to the plate in front of her daughter.

“Your eggs are getting cold.”

“I know.”

She reached for the last piece of toast.

For the moment, Nwagaga let her eat without another instruction.

Late that morning, Akudo brought the photograph to the sitting room.

David had moved the bassinet near the window while he folded a small pile of baby clothes. Kamsi was awake now, examining the light on the ceiling with an expression that suggested he had discovered something important.

Akudo sat beside him and held the photograph so she could see it clearly.

Her mother had been young in the picture. She was wearing a patterned blouse, with her first son in her arms. The baby was wrapped in a light cloth. His face was turned slightly toward the camera.

Akudo had looked at the photograph several times since Saturday.

Each time, she noticed another detail.

A bracelet on Nwagaga's wrist. A folded wrapper over the back of the chair. A doorway behind her, partly hidden by somebody standing out of the frame.

She wondered whether her grandmother had been there when the picture was taken.

David sat beside her.

“Did your sister know?”

“No.”

“Did she take it well?”

“She wants answers, same as me.”

David watched her turn the photograph over.

“I wish I could have met him,” Akudo said.

“So do I.”

She looked at him.

“Do you mean that?”

“Of course.”

“You never knew him.”

“Neither did you. That doesn't mean you can't wish you had.”

Akudo placed the photograph beside her on the sofa.

She was still angry that David had known about her brother before she did. Their conversation the night before had made that easier to discuss, but it had not undone the hurt.

“I don't want us keeping things like this from Kamsi,” she said.

“Neither do I.”

“Even difficult things.”

“We'll have to learn how to tell him things he can understand when he's old enough.”

“I don't want to make him afraid of his own family.”

David followed her gaze.

“Then we'll be careful about the stories we tell.”

Kamsi stretched one leg, made a small noise, and returned his attention to the ceiling.

“Your mother says I'm improving.”

“She told you that?”

“She said my folding only looked a little like a handkerchief this time.”

Akudo inspected the shirt.

“She's right.”

Mrs. Carter knocked shortly after two o'clock.

She was carrying a small shopping bag and a covered dish. Nwagaga answered the door and immediately attempted to take both from her.

“Margaret! Come in.”

“Only for a minute. I brought back your container.”

“Did you wash it?”

“Of course.”

“Then you are welcome.”

Mrs. Carter entered, looking pleased with herself.

“I also wanted to tell you something.”

Akudo came from the sitting room, where she had just finished feeding Kamsi.

“What happened?”

“Do you remember the couple at the end of the corridor? The ones with the twins?”

“Yes,” Akudo said.

“I went over this morning.”

Nwagaga drew out a chair.

“And?”

“I asked whether they needed anything from the grocery store. The father told me they were managing perfectly well.”

David, coming in from the kitchen, raised an eyebrow.

“That sounds familiar.”

“So I asked the mother instead,” Mrs. Carter continued. “She said they had plenty of baby blankets, but neither of them had cooked a proper dinner in days.”

“What did you say?” Nwagaga asked.

“I told her I could bring something on Tuesday.”

Mrs. Carter set the covered dish on the table.

“She needed somebody to bring dinner on Tuesday. I can do Tuesday.”

Nwagaga pulled out another chair.

“Then sit and let me find you something to drink.”

“Oh, I really can't stay long.”

“You said that last time.”

“And I stayed nearly two hours.”

“Exactly. Today we shall try one.”

Mrs. Carter accepted the chair.

She explained that the couple had agreed to let her help with groceries too. Their relatives lived far away, and both parents were exhausted. She had asked what they actually needed before making promises.

“I don't know whether I can do anything like your Omugwo,” she said, “but I can cook a meal.”

“That is plenty,” Akudo told her.

Nwagaga had already gone to the kitchen to find something to serve their visitor. David followed her, carrying the empty dish.

Mrs. Carter turned toward Akudo.

“How are you feeling today, darling?”

“Better. Still tired.”

“Is your mother looking after you?”

“Yes. And she's learning that she doesn't have to rearrange our whole apartment to do it.”

From the kitchen, Nwagaga called, “I heard that!”

“You were supposed to, Mom.”

Mrs. Carter took a sip of the water David brought her.

It was a small visit. They spoke about the twins, the weather, and the difficulties of finding a reliable lift in the building. Nobody delivered another speech about motherhood.

When Mrs. Carter left, she carried a portion of food Nwagaga had packed for her. She promised to return the container whenever she was passing.

Nwagaga watched her cross the corridor.

“She's a good woman.”

“She is,” Akudo said.

Her mother closed the door and went back to the kitchen.

* * *

By evening, the apartment had returned to its familiar mixture of kitchen sounds and baby noises.

David was setting the table. Akudo sat nearby with Kamsi resting in his bassinet after a feeding. Nwagaga stood at the stove, finishing a pot of stew to accompany the yam she had cooked.

Akudo watched her mother taste the stew and reach for the salt.

“Mom?”

“Hmm?”

“How long are you staying?”

Nwagaga turned.

“Why?”

“I want to know.”

“Do you want me to go?”

“No.”

“Then why are you asking?”

“Because David and I need to make plans. And because I'd like to know how much time we have together.”

Nwagaga set down the spoon.

She had answered the question differently when she arrived on Thursday. Back then, she had treated the length of her visit as something only she could decide.

Now she glanced toward David.

“What do you think, my son?”

He took a moment to answer.

“I think we still need help. But we should probably work out how long you can stay and what happens afterward.”

“And you, Akudo?”

“I want you here. I also want us to make the arrangements together.”

Nwagaga considered them both.

“Very well. After dinner, we shall check my return ticket and decide what works.”

David moved another plate onto the table.

“We get a vote?”

“You have always had a vote, my son.”

He glanced toward Akudo.

She raised an eyebrow but said nothing.

Nwagaga pointed her spoon at him.

“Although if you vote that I should leave tomorrow, you will have to explain who is cooking all this food.”

“I wasn't planning to vote tomorrow.”

“Good. Then carry the yam to the table.”

He obeyed.

Akudo stood to help, but Nwagaga stopped her.

“Sit. You've done enough today.”

“Mom, I can carry a bowl.”

“I know you can. David is already standing.”

Akudo sat back down.

The answer had come without an argument. Perhaps her mother was learning when to leave a thing alone.

As David brought the food over, Nwagaga filled Akudo's bowl first. The stew was warm and fragrant, and the yam had been cut into pieces small enough to eat easily.

“Mom?”

“Yes, nwa m?”

“Thank you for coming.”

Nwagaga paused with the serving spoon in her hand.

“Where else would I be?”

Akudo did not tell her that there were several places she could have been. Nigeria, for one, where she had left her own home and responsibilities. Or visiting relatives who had been asking when she would return.

She knew her mother had chosen to come.

Nwagaga served David, took a portion for herself, and joined them at the table.

They ate while Kamsi slept nearby. At some point, David got up to refill the water glasses. Nwagaga asked whether anyone wanted more stew, and Akudo declined without having to explain herself.

After dinner, there would be dishes to wash, another feeding, and perhaps more time spent persuading Kamsi that night was meant for sleeping.

There would also be the return ticket to discuss.

And the photograph Akudo still had to send her sister.

She had placed it beside her grandmother's letter in a drawer, where she could find them both. She had not decided what should happen to the originals, or whether her sister would want copies of every page.

That conversation could wait until they had finished eating.

Nwagaga reached across the table for the serving bowl.

David passed it to her.

From the bassinet came a small complaint.

“Ah,” Nwagaga said, putting down the spoon. “Our chairman has something to say.”

Akudo rose to check on her son.

Behind her, David began clearing space on the table. Nwagaga called after Akudo to ask whether she needed anything.

“I'm fine, Mom,” Akudo said.

She lifted Kamsi and settled him against her shoulder.

At the dining table, Nwagaga reached for her own plate and began eating before the food grew cold.

Epilogue: One Mother Does Not Raise a Child

Three weeks later, Nwagaga announced that she was going home to Nigeria.

She chose Saturday morning to break the news, while David was drinking tea and Akudo was trying to persuade Kamsi that a clean shirt was a perfectly reasonable thing to wear.

“I am leaving on Thursday,” Nwagaga said.

Akudo paused.

“This Thursday?”

“Akudo, how many Thursdays do you know?”

Akudo had been asking about her mother's return ticket since the first day of the visit. They had finally agreed on a date, and she had known it was coming. Yet hearing Nwagaga say it aloud was different.

“Thursday is very soon.”

“It is five days away.”

“Exactly.”

“My daughter, you complained that I moved your pots. Now you want me to remain here and supervise them forever?”

“I never said forever.”

“Then how long?”

Akudo concentrated on fastening Kamsi’s shirt.

Nwagaga returned to the stove, evidently satisfied that she had won the exchange.

David took Kamsi from Akudo and carried him past the kitchen doorway.

“For the record, Mom, I can find most things now.”

“Most?”

“I'm still looking for the large sieve.”

“Second cupboard, behind the bowls.”

David stopped.

“Why is it behind the bowls?”

“Because that is where I found space.”

Akudo caught his expression. He had been asking about the sieve for two weeks, and her mother had apparently known its location all along.

“Five days,” Akudo said. “Then we can arrange the kitchen ourselves.”

“Excellent,” David replied. “Our independence is approaching.”

Nwagaga turned down the stove.

“Independence does not mean somebody will come and cook your lunch.”

“We know, Mom.”

“Good. I have been waiting for you people to remember.”

* * *

By Monday, the kitchen counter was covered with containers.

Nwagaga had made pepper soup, portioned stew, and prepared other dishes Akudo could warm without standing over the stove for long. She had labelled the containers with the contents and dates. There was pap for breakfast, white yam in the cupboard, and enough dried ingredients left over to make David wonder whether they would ever need to visit a Nigerian grocery shop again.

Akudo stood at the refrigerator reading the notes her mother had attached with magnets.

Soup in the freezer. Warm only what you need.

Eat before you become too tired to remember food.

A third note carried the number of a friend Nwagaga trusted, along with a reminder that Mrs. Carter lived across the hall and had already offered to help.

Akudo touched the edge of the second note.

In three weeks, Nwagaga had done far more than cook. She had washed baby clothes, stayed beside Kamsi while Akudo slept, answered questions, and learned, sometimes reluctantly, when to leave her daughter to make a decision.

There had been disagreements too.

Akudo still remembered their first argument about her work emails and the kitchen cupboards. Nwagaga had not stopped giving instructions, but she had begun asking where things belonged before

moving them. David could now prepare breakfast without needing to search three different cupboards for a saucepan.

“Mom,” Akudo called, “you've left us enough food for a small party.”

“Then don't invite anybody. Eat it yourselves.”

“What will you eat when you get home?”

Nwagaga came into the kitchen carrying another container.

“Have I forgotten how to cook because I spent three weeks in America?”

“You might need a rest.”

“I will rest when I get home.”

Akudo took the container from her.

“Then let me finish packing these.”

Nwagaga hesitated, glanced at the open freezer, and stepped aside.

* * *

On Tuesday, Mrs. Carter arrived with a basket of muffins and fruit.

“I thought you might appreciate something you didn't have to cook,” she told Nwagaga.

“Margaret! You are bringing food for me now?”

“Of course.”

“So you have decided to do Omugwo for the grandmother.”

Mrs. Carter laughed.

“I don't know about that, but I can certainly bring muffins.”

She sat at the kitchen table while Akudo made tea. Over the past three weeks, Mrs. Carter had become a familiar visitor. She no longer needed to be persuaded to stay for a drink, although she still checked whether the pepper soup was mild before accepting a bowl.

“How are the twins?” Nwagaga asked.

“Busy keeping their parents awake. I took dinner over yesterday, and their mother told me she'd finally managed to have a proper afternoon nap.”

“Good.”

“I've arranged to bring something again next Tuesday.”

Mrs. Carter turned to Akudo.

“The father keeps thanking me for the cooking, but I think the biggest help is that neither of them has to decide what they're eating after a difficult day.”

Akudo understood. Sometimes a meal appearing on the table had mattered more than any advice she had received.

“That's exactly how I felt,” she said.

Mrs. Carter reached for another muffin.

“Then I'm glad I asked what they needed.”

They spent the rest of the visit discussing Nwagaga's journey and whether Houston would have another storm before the month ended. When Mrs. Carter left, she promised to check on Akudo and David after Nwagaga had gone.

“Not every day,” Akudo warned.

“Certainly not. I'll give you at least until Friday.”

Nwagaga approved of that arrangement.

* * *

On Wednesday evening, Akudo helped her mother pack.

The guest room looked smaller without the bags and clothes that had filled it during the visit. Nwagaga had already wrapped her perfume bottle in a soft cloth and placed her shoes along one side of the suitcase. The framed photograph of Akudo's father lay on the bed, ready to be protected between two folded wrappers.

Akudo held up a blouse.

“Are you sure you need to take all these things back? You could leave some here.”

“And then arrive home with half my clothes missing?”

“You'll come again.”

“I know. But I would like to have something to wear before then.”

Akudo folded the blouse and put it in the suitcase.

On the bedside table lay the photograph of Nwagaga with her first son. Akudo had brought it in after speaking to her sister again that afternoon. Her sister wanted a copy of their grandmother’s letter too, but they had agreed to read it together when they could talk properly.

Akudo picked up the photograph.

“I sent her a picture of this.”

“What did she say?” Nwagaga asked.

“She wanted to know his name again. Then she asked whether you had any more photographs.”

“I'll find what I have when I get home.”

“She wants to call you.”

“I'll answer.”

Akudo sat on the edge of the bed.

Her anger had changed during the weeks since she opened the envelope. It no longer rose every time Nwagaga entered the room, but it had not disappeared. There were still questions about her brother, her grandmother, and the years when both parents had kept the family history to themselves.

Nwagaga closed a drawer.

“Are you still angry with me?”

“A little.”

Her mother came to sit beside her.

“That is fair.”

“I don't think I'll ever understand why you couldn't tell us.”

“I know.”

“I wish Dad had told me too.”

Nwagaga reached for the photograph.

“Your father loved that boy. He found it difficult to speak of him afterward.”

Akudo traced the edge of the paper with her thumb.

“I wish I had known him.”

“So do I, nwa m.”

Nwagaga told her one more small thing: the baby had liked being carried near the kitchen while she cooked. Sometimes her husband would walk slowly from one room to another, describing what he was doing as if the child were old enough to answer.

Akudo pictured her father with a baby against his shoulder.

She had seen him carry her younger brother that way. Until now, she had never imagined an earlier child in his arms.

“Will you tell us more when you're ready?” she asked.

“I will.”

Akudo handed the photograph back. Nwagaga placed it beside the wrapped picture of her husband, then returned to packing.

A few minutes later, Akudo asked, “Mom, when I have another baby, will you come again?”

Nwagaga turned from the suitcase.

“Another baby?”

“Not tomorrow!”

“Good. Because first we must teach this one that night is for sleeping.”

Akudo picked up the last blouse.

“So you'll come?”

“Where else would I be?”

* * *

Thursday morning arrived with light rain.

David carried Nwagaga's suitcase to the door while Akudo stood in the sitting room with Kamsi in her arms. The windows were streaked with water, and the sky beyond the apartment buildings was grey. Nwagaga had been dressed for nearly an hour, but she was still finding reasons to walk back into the kitchen.

“Did you see the stew in the bottom drawer of the freezer?”

“Yes, Mom.”

“And the pap?”

“Yes,” Akudo answered.

Nwagaga inspected her son-in-law.

“My son, I am leaving my daughter and grandson in your care.”

David set down the suitcase.

“I'll look after them, Mom.”

“And yourself. Somebody has to remember to eat.”

“I've learned from the best.”

“Very good.”

She turned to Kamsi.

“Come, my boy.”

Akudo passed him over. Nwagaga held him against her, supporting him securely while she straightened his little shirt. His eyes were open,

though he seemed less interested in the departure than in the pattern on his grandmother's scarf.

“Kamsiyochukwu,” she said. “Your grandmother is travelling.”

Kamsi moved one hand.

“You have been giving us plenty of work these past weeks.”

“He's been very helpful,” David said.

“He has taught us how little sleep a person can survive on.”

Nwagaga laughed.

“He is only a baby.”

She looked down at Kamsi again.

“Grow well, nwa m.”

For a while she held him without saying anything else. Then she handed him back to Akudo and adjusted the edge of his blanket.

The taxi was waiting outside.

Nwagaga turned toward her daughter.

“Akudo.”

“Yes, Mom?”

“Ị mere nke ọma. You have done well.”

Akudo swallowed.

“I've asked you questions every day. I've been upset with you. Sometimes I couldn't even tell why Kamsi was crying.”

“And still you have been caring for him.”

“I couldn't have managed these weeks without you.”

“You had David too. And Margaret. Remember that.”

Akudo glanced toward her husband, who had gone to check whether the taxi driver needed help with the bags.

When she turned back, Nwagaga was holding out her hands.

Akudo stepped forward, and her mother drew her close.

For a few seconds, neither spoke. Akudo could smell the perfume her mother had worn since she was a child. She had grown accustomed to that scent moving through the apartment each morning, to the sound of Nwagaga preparing breakfast, and to her voice calling from the kitchen whenever she wanted someone to find kitchen utensils or taste a pot of soup.

“Call when you land,” Akudo said.

“Of course.”

“And when you get home.”

“I will.”

“Even if you're tired.”

“Now who is giving instructions?”

Akudo released her mother.

Nwagaga picked up her handbag, checked once more that she had her passport, and stepped into the hallway. David took the suitcase toward the lift.

Akudo remained in the doorway with Kamsi until they disappeared around the corner.

* * *

The apartment was quieter that afternoon.

David played with Kamsi while Akudo warmed some of the stew Nwagaga had prepared. At first she reached automatically for the cooking spoon beside the stove, then remembered her mother had moved it back to its original drawer before leaving.

She opened the drawer.

There it was.

Beside it lay a folded note in Nwagaga's handwriting.

Eat before the food gets cold.

Akudo left it on the counter while she finished warming lunch.

That evening, Mrs. Carter stopped by with a container of soup. She had seen the taxi leave that morning and wanted to know how the family was managing.

“So far, nobody has rearranged the kitchen,” David told her.

“Give it a day,” Mrs. Carter said.

Akudo put the soup in the refrigerator. When she returned, David was holding Kamsi, who had begun protesting the delay before his next feeding.

Mrs. Carter stayed only long enough to ask whether they needed anything from the shops. Akudo thanked her and said they were all right for now.

After she left, Akudo fed Kamsi and settled beside David on the sofa.

Outside, Houston carried on as usual. Cars passed through the wet streets, and a neighbour's television could be heard faintly through the wall. In the kitchen, the refrigerator hummed around the meals Nwagaga had left behind.

Kamsi grew sleepy against Akudo's shoulder.

David glanced toward the empty rocking chair.

“It's strange without Mom here.”

“It is,” Akudo agreed.

“Who is going to tell me I'm folding his shirts wrong?”

“She’ll call,” Akudo said.

As if she had heard them, Akudo's phone lit up on the side table.

Mom calling.

Akudo answered.

“Mom! Have you reached the airport?”

“Yes, my daughter. I am waiting to board. Have you eaten?”

David heard the question and raised his eyebrows.

“We have, Mom,” Akudo said.

Akudo told her about the stew and Mrs. Carter's visit. They spoke for a few minutes, and Nwagaga promised to call again after she reached Nigeria.

When the call ended, Akudo placed the phone beside her.

Kamsi had fallen asleep. She watched his small hand resting against her shirt and thought about the photograph of her older brother, now tucked safely inside the drawer in their bedroom.

There were stories she would tell her son when he was old enough to understand them. Some would be funny: his grandmother arguing about onions, David trying to fold a newborn shirt, and the afternoon Mrs. Carter discovered how much pepper a little bowl of soup could hold.

Others would take longer to tell.

David leaned closer to check on Kamsi.

“Is he asleep?”

“For now.”

He reached for the blanket folded over the arm of the sofa.

Akudo rested against his shoulder while he drew it across her legs.

After all, a baby may arrive in one mother's arms, but no mother should have to carry the whole journey alone.

The End

Glossary of Igbo Words and Cultural Expressions

A guide to the language, food, traditions, and family references in this story.

Ahn-ahn — A common Nigerian expression used to show surprise, disbelief, annoyance, or emphasis. Its meaning depends on the speaker's tone and the situation.

Chineke — God. It may also be used as an exclamation of surprise, concern, or strong emotion.

Daalụ — Thank you. In some Igbo-speaking communities, it is also used as a greeting.

Ehuru — Calabash nutmeg, an aromatic spice commonly used in Nigerian cooking, including pepper soup.

Igbo — An ethnic group and language associated primarily with southeastern Nigeria. Igbo communities have rich traditions of family life, storytelling, food, naming, and communal care. Practices vary among families and communities.

Ị bọọla chi? — A traditional morning greeting, roughly meaning “Have you woken up?” It serves as a way of saying good morning in some Igbo-speaking communities.

Ị mere nke ọma — You did well. An expression of praise or encouragement.

Kedu? — A greeting that can mean “How are you?” or “How is it going?”, depending on context.

M̀má — The affectionate family name by which Akudo knows her maternal grandmother. In this story, it always refers to Nwagaga's mother.

Ndo — Sorry. It can express sympathy, comfort, or an apology, depending on context.

Nwa m — My child. An affectionate expression used by a parent or older relative.

Omugwo — An Igbo tradition of caring for a mother and her newborn after childbirth. A mother, mother-in-law, or another trusted relative may stay with the family to cook, help with household responsibilities, care for the baby, and support the mother's rest and recovery. The arrangements and customs differ between families. Omugwo is a tradition of practical and emotional support, not a substitute for professional medical care.

Pap — A soft, cooked porridge, commonly made from fermented maize in Nigeria. It is also called *ogi* or *akamu* in different communities and is often eaten at breakfast.

Pepper soup — A Nigerian dish made with a seasoned broth, pepper, aromatic spices, and ingredients such as meat or fish. Recipes vary widely among households and regions.

Scent leaves — Aromatic leaves used in Nigerian cooking to add flavour to soups and stews.

Uda — An aromatic spice used in some traditional Nigerian soups and dishes, including pepper soup.

Ụtụtụ ọma — Good morning.

Uziza — A Nigerian culinary plant whose leaves or seeds are used to add a distinctive peppery flavour to food.

Wrapper — A length of fabric worn around the waist, commonly by women in Nigeria and other parts of West Africa. It can be worn for everyday activities, celebrations, or traditional occasions.

Yam — A starchy tuber widely eaten in Nigeria. It may be boiled, roasted, fried, or prepared in other ways. The white yam served in this story is different from the orange-fleshed sweet potato commonly called a yam in some American supermarkets.

A Note on the Characters' Names

Rosiline Akudo (Akudo) — The mother of Kamsi and daughter of Nwagaga. Although her full name is Rosiline Akudo, her family and the narration usually call her Akudo.

Nwagaga (Mom) — Akudo's mother, who travels from Nigeria to Houston to help her daughter during Omugwo. Akudo and David call her Mom.

Kamsiyochukwu (Kamsi) / Henry — Akudo and David's baby boy. **Kamsiyochukwu and Henry are his two given names.** Kamsi is the familiar shortened form of Kamsiyochukwu, not a third name.

M̀má — Akudo's late grandmother and Nwagaga's mother. Her letter becomes an important part of the family's story.

Nnenna — A woman from the family's earlier generations whose name is associated with the old firstborn promise mentioned in M̀má's letter. The family's beliefs about that promise reflect its history of grief and fear; the story does not establish that a supernatural curse exists.

Igbo expressions may have regional variations in pronunciation, spelling, and usage. The explanations above reflect how the words and cultural references are used in this story.

About the Creators

About Ifeoma Clark

Ifeoma Clark is the writer of Omugwo: The Season Mother Came, a novella about motherhood, family memory, and the care that sustains new parents. Her storytelling brings humour and emotional depth to an Igbo family navigating life across Nigeria and the United States.

About Henry Loveday

Henry Loveday developed the original story and its central creative vision. Omugwo: The Season Mother Came reflects his interest in the importance of supporting mothers, preserving family stories, and recognising care as a responsibility shared across generations.

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